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James 1:1–11

James

James 1:1–11

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 1:1–11 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 1:1–11 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 1:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

James is writing this letter in Jerusalem, where James is an important leader among the Jewish believers. James writes a general letter that he does not intend for a specific church, person, or situation. James gives practical advice in his letter to all believers about how to live their lives as believers. It is possible, but not likely, that there was only one copy of the letter and that someone then took it to each community of believers one at a time. It is more likely that somebody made several copies of the letter, and then several people each took a copy of the letter with them to read it to a small number, or a community, of believers.

At the time James wrote this letter, most writers of letters like this would start the letter in the same way. The letter writer would say who was writing the letter, then to whom they were writing, and then add a greeting. James does this, and then James gives a summary of what the letter will be about.

James starts by saying that he is James, a servant of God and a servant of the Lord Jesus Christ. When James says that he is a servant, or slave, of the Lord Jesus Christ, James is showing that he has great humility and great respect for Jesus and God the Father. James says that he is writing the letter to the “12 tribes” who are now living in groups in many different places outside of Jerusalem. The 12 tribes were the descendants of the 12 sons of Jacob. This probably means that James is writing his letter for the Israelites, or Jews, who are now followers of Jesus and living outside of Jerusalem. It is likely that there were communities of believers around the eastern end of the Mediterranean Sea. It is possible that non-Jewish believers were also part of the groups that James was writing to.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel during James’ time and the surrounding area as a group. The map shows where there were communities of Jewish people who no longer lived in Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

Now, James talks directly to the believers he is writing the letter to. James calls the believers “brothers and sisters,” although they are not blood relatives of James. The believers are brothers and sisters because, with James, they are all part of God’s family.

James begins by telling the believers that they can be very glad, or have joy, when difficult things happen to the believers. Joy is more than just being happy. Someone has joy when they are thankful to God and strongly trust God.

James says that if the believers can experience the difficult things and still trust and believe in God as strongly as before, then the believers will become mature, or perfect, and will have everything they need. James does not mean that the believers will have all the material possessions they need, or that they will never make mistakes.

James means that the believers will be spiritually mature. In this letter, James talks several times about the believers being perfect, or mature.

What James is saying is that when believers go through difficult things, the believers learn to trust and rely on God all the time, not just when something goes wrong. To trust God becomes a normal part of a believer's life, not just something a believer does when things are hard. And when a believer has learnt to trust God all the time, they are fully mature, or "perfect." That believer is complete, or able to trust God, because they have everything they need to trust God.

The difficult things that James is talking about can be when people treat someone badly because that person follows Jesus. Difficult things can also be the hard things, like death, sickness, and loss, that happen to people every day.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture or community, what "difficult things" do people experience in their everyday lives? This could be things like not having enough money to buy food for your family, too much or too little rain to grow food, or difficulties traveling somewhere. Pause this audio here.

James then says that if the believers do not know how God wants them to live like they fully trust God, then the believers should ask God to make them wise. God will give the believers the wisdom they ask for freely and generously, and will not make the believers do anything in return. This shows that God loves and cares for the believers. James is not saying that God will give the believers everything they ask for, or that God will always tell the believers exactly what to do in every situation. James is saying that if God makes the believers wise, the believers will understand how God wants them to live and how to go through the difficult things.

James then says that when the believers ask for wisdom, the believers must have confidence in God, rather than confidence that God will answer their prayer. The opposite of having confidence in someone, or trusting someone, is to doubt that person. James says that the person who doubts God is like a wave in the sea or on a lake. The wind is blowing the wave so that the wave is always moving, but is not going anywhere. For the Jews, the sea and waves often represented chaos, danger, and uncertainty, so this tells us that James thinks that doubt is a bad thing. A person who doubts is not just a person who cannot make a decision. A person who doubts thinks about following God, and then thinks about following other people who do not follow God. This person never fully commits to either side, so this person is always restless and never makes any progress. James says that God will not answer the person who doubts. A person who doubts will want to follow God and want to follow the people in the world, so this person will not be able to decide about anything that they do.

Stop here and look at a video of the wind blowing a wave around. Pause this audio here.

James goes on to talk about rich and poor believers. Poor believers have few possessions and a low social status. Rich believers have wealth and possessions. James says that both poor and rich believers can be "proud." In the Bible, when someone is proud, it is often a bad thing, but here James says that being proud in this way is a good thing. Here, when someone is proud, it means that the person rejoices or gives glory to God.

The humble believers can be proud because God gives them spiritual riches. James suggests that if rich or wealthy people understand that their wealth and status are temporary and do not last, then the rich people can also be proud. Both poor and rich believers should know that God does not value them based on how much money they have, but on how much these believers trust God and have a relationship with God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture or community, what makes somebody rich? Is it money, or land, or something else? Does your culture value rich people more than poor people? How do you treat people who were once wealthy but lose their wealth? Pause this audio here.

James reminds the rich people that their wealth and status will not last forever, just like flowers that grow in the wild do not live forever. These flowers can be very beautiful, but when they are under a hot sun, the flowers can wither and die quickly. When James was writing this part of the letter, James might also have been thinking about the words of Jesus when Jesus said, "Do not store up treasures on earth where someone can destroy or steal them. Store up treasures in heaven. Your mind and heart will be focused on where your treasures are."

Stop here and look at a photo of a flower flowering, a flower dying, and a flower shedding its petals.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 1:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four parts.

In the first part: James starts the letter by saying who James is, who James is writing the letter to, and greets the Jewish believers.

In the second part: James tells the believers it is important for them to continue to trust God when the believers are going through various kinds of difficulties. God uses these trials to test the believers' faith.

In the third part: James says that the believers need God's wisdom in order to remain faithful to God, and so the believers should ask God for wisdom. James also encourages believers that when they pray to God, the believers should completely trust God.

In the fourth part: James says that both rich and poor believers should trust God and learn to think about poverty and wealth as God does.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- God
- Jesus Christ
- The Jewish believers who are not living in or close to Jerusalem
- Some Jewish believers who doubt God
- Some Jewish believers who are poor
- And some Jewish believers who are rich

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Remember that James wrote this letter in Jerusalem. A person then traveled with the letter to the people James was writing to, and then somebody read the letter to the believers.

James starts his letter the same way most people wrote letters at this time. James begins this letter with who is writing the letter, who the letter is addressed to, and a greeting.

James says that he is writing the letter, and that he is James, a servant of God and a servant of the Lord Jesus Christ. James does not need to say anything else about who James is because everybody who hears the letter will know who is writing it. James says that he is writing the letter to the "12 tribes" who are living in the diaspora, or in many different places outside of Jerusalem. The 12 tribes were the 12 Jewish tribes that we hear about in the stories in the Old Testament. Here, James means that he is writing his letter to Jewish believers. The greeting that James gives is the same as saying "Hello." The word that James uses is very similar to the word that means "joy," so James' greeting could also mean "Be glad" or "Be joyful."

Stop here and discuss as a group: When you send a message to a group of people, how do you change your words or phrases based on whether those people know you or not? If you want to greet people joyfully in your culture, what word or phrase would you use to greet them? Think about whether this will change how you translate this letter. Pause this audio here.

In the second part of this introduction to his letter, James talks directly to the believers he is writing the letter to. James calls the believers "brothers and sisters," although they are not blood relatives of James. The believers are brothers and sisters because, with James, they are all part of God's family.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What words do you use when you talk to other believers that you know and love? Talk about how you will translate "brothers and sisters" in these passages. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that they can be very glad, or have joy, when difficult things happen to them. In other words, the believers can be thankful and strongly trust God when difficult things happen to them.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about somebody who has a deep and thankful trust in God. Pay attention to the words and phrases you use when you are talking about this person. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers they can be glad because, as they experience difficult things, they will learn to trust God more and more. Eventually, these believers will learn to trust and rely on God all the time, not just when something goes wrong. These believers will be mature and complete. The difficult things that James is talking about can be when people persecute or treat believers badly. The difficult things can also be the difficult things that happen to people every day.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about how a believer who is still immature would react to a difficult situation, and then how a believer who is mature would react to the same situation. Pay attention to the words and phrases you use when you are describing these people. Pause this audio here.

In the third part, James says that believers should ask God for wisdom. God will freely and generously give the believers the wisdom they ask for, and will not expect anything in return. This shows that God loves and cares for the believers. James is not saying that God will give the believers everything they ask for, or that God will always tell the believers exactly what to do in every situation. James is saying that the wisdom that God gives will help the believers to understand how God wants them to live and how to behave when difficult things happen.

James goes on to say that when the believers ask God for wisdom, the believers must trust God. The opposite of trusting God is doubting God. James talks about the person who doubts God by saying the person is like a wave that constantly moves in the sea or on a lake. This person is somebody who sometimes chooses to act in one way and then another time, decides to act in a different way. This person never fully commits to either side, so this person is always restless and never makes any progress.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Put some water into a bowl and have two or three people blow on the water to move it around. Notice how the water moves. Now, as you think about how the water moves, discuss what words or phrases you would use to talk about somebody who doubts in the way that James describes. Pause this audio here.

In the fourth part, James says that both rich and poor believers should trust God and learn to think about being poor and being rich in the same way that God thinks about these things.

The humble believers can be proud because God gives these believers spiritual riches. The wealthy believers can be proud if they understand that their wealth and status are temporary and do not last. Both poor and rich believers should know that God does not value them based on how much money they have, but on how much they trust God and have a relationship with God. James reminds the rich people that their wealth and status are temporary, just like flowers that grow in the wild. These flowers can be very beautiful, but when they are under a hot sun, the flowers can wither and die quickly.

James talks about wealth and possessions that do not last. James might have been thinking about the words of Jesus when Jesus said, “Do not store up treasures on earth where someone can destroy or steal them. Store up treasures in heaven. Your mind and heart will be focused on where your treasures are.”

Stop here and discuss as a group: Can you think of a plant, flower, or object that looks beautiful but does not last long in harsh conditions? How does this help you understand that money and things do not last forever? Will people easily understand the idea of a flower blooming and dying, or is there another description that would make more sense? Talk together about the words and images you will use when you translate this part of the passage. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it. You may want to use people or objects to show James, God, Jesus, and the different groups of believers. As you retell the story, you could have James stand with God and Jesus to show that James is their servant. You could have the different groups of believers stand in different parts of the space where you are, to show that the believers lived in many different places. Remember how James talks about waves moving around to show that people doubt, and how flowers die to show how money and things go away. How will you show these ideas?

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 1:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- God
- Jesus Christ
- The Jewish believers who are not living in or close to Jerusalem
- Some Jewish believers who doubt God
- Some Jewish believers who are poor
- And some Jewish believers who are rich

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

James says the words, and someone who is with James writes down what James says. As James speaks, the believers act out what James says.

James says, "I am James, a slave of God and a slave of the Lord Jesus Christ. I am sending this letter to all the Jewish believers who have left Jerusalem and are now living in other places. Hello!"

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who are living in many other places, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I used to be part of the community of believers in Jerusalem. It is so good to know that I can still have teaching from James; or
- There are so many of us, and we live all over the place. I am glad that James is writing to all of us. It makes me feel like we are still part of the same church.

Continue the drama.

James says, "Brothers and sisters, you can be very glad when difficult things happen to you, because when difficult things happen to you, you will become stronger, and it will become easier to trust God. And when trusting God becomes a normal part of your life, not just something you do when things are hard, then you will be complete, and God's work is done!"

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing James, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- It is difficult to say things like this when I do not know what difficult things these people are going through. I hope these people know that I want to encourage them; or
- I am sad that the Jewish believers had to leave Jerusalem. I would like to see the Jewish believers again.

Continue the drama.

James says, “If you do not know how to work through difficult situations, then you need to ask God for wisdom. Because God loves you and cares for you, God will give you wisdom freely and generously without conditions. God will not tell you exactly what to do, but God’s wisdom will help you understand how God wants you to live and how to get through the difficult things.”

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I love the believers, and I want to help them. It makes me sad when the believers do not ask me for wisdom; or
- Sometimes the believers behave like little children and then want me to do everything for them. I feel sad. I want the believers to grow up and be mature believers.

Continue the drama.

James then says, “When you ask God for wisdom, ask with confidence and trust, without doubt. A person who doubts God is like a wave in the sea or on a lake, which the wind blows about. The wave constantly moves but does not go anywhere. If you doubt, then God will not answer your prayer for wisdom.”

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who the wind is blowing about, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am frightened. I am scared that if I ask God for wisdom, God might not answer me; or
- I am confused. I do not know what to do.

Continue the drama.

James says, “The community looks down on believers who are poor because they do not have wealth or possessions. But these believers can be proud because they have spiritual riches. The poor believers have spiritual riches because God honors them, and these believers have a future in God’s kingdom. And you believers who have wealth and possessions, you can also be proud because God also gives you spiritual riches. But you need to remember that wealth and status are temporary, just like flowers that grow in the wild. These flowers can be very beautiful, but when they are under a hot sun, the flowers can wither and die quickly.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who are poor, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Sometimes, when people hate me and look down on me, it is very hard to remember that I have spiritual riches; or
- I am so glad that I have few possessions. I think it makes it easier for me to remember that I have spiritual riches.

Ask the person playing the believers who are rich, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am glad that James is reminding me that all my wealth and possessions are temporary; or
- I do not like to hear this. Sometimes I would rather have possessions that I can see and touch than spiritual riches.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 1:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James starts his letter by describing himself as a servant, or slave. A slave belongs to a master and obeys the master, and the master has the right to tell the slave to do whatever the master wants him to do.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **servant** or **slave**. If you have translated servant or slave in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about servant and slave. Pause this audio here.

James describes himself as a servant of God and the Lord Jesus Christ. Use the same word for God that you have used throughout your translation. Lord means "owner" or "master," but in the Bible it has a special meaning. Lord is a title of respect and of authority. It is one title for God in the Old Testament, and in the New Testament, "Lord" usually refers to Jesus. In the letter of James, "Lord" usually refers to God, but in this greeting, James uses it for Jesus.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **Lord** and **Christ**. If you have translated Lord or Christ in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about Lord and Christ. Pause this audio here.

James is writing this letter to the 12 tribes who live in the diaspora, or in many different places around the world. The 12 tribes refer to the descendants of the 12 sons of Jacob. This is another way to talk about the Jewish people. Because James is writing the letter to believers, we can assume that James is writing to Jewish people who had become followers of Jesus and had moved away from Jerusalem to live in other places. Some people think that James was writing the letter for all new believers who live in other places, not just to Jewish believers. James calls these other places the diaspora, which means that people live in many different cities and nations. You may say that these people live in many different places or nations.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **12 tribes** and **diaspora**. Pause this audio here.

James addresses the believers as **brothers** here and several more times throughout this letter. We can be certain that James also wanted women to hear his letter. Some translations use the words "brothers and sisters," and some simply say "believers." The believers are not the blood relatives of James. The believers are brothers and sisters because, with James, they are all part of God's family.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **brothers** or **brothers and sisters**. If you choose to use a word for **believers**, refer to the Master Glossary for more information about believers. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that they can be very glad or full of joy when bad things happen to test their faith. When someone has faith, that person trusts that God is good and that God will do what he has promised, even when it seems impossible. Joy is a deep happiness that people have when they know and trust God, no matter what happens.

Stop here and discuss what words or phrases you will use for **joy** and **faith**. If you have translated joy in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Discuss what word or phrase you will use for faith. If you have translated faith in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about faith. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that trials will test their faith. Trials are difficult situations or challenges that test how strong you are, how patient you are, or how much you trust God. Trials can come from problems that are often beyond your control, such as losing a job, having a serious illness, or dealing with a natural disaster.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **trials**. If you have translated trials in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that when bad things test their faith, the believers will have more perseverance. When someone perseveres, they continue to trust God again and again, even when hard things happen.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **perseverance**. If you have translated perseverance in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that when someone perseveres, that person becomes perfect and complete. This means the person keeps trusting God and does not give up during difficult times. As the believers continue through these challenges, their character and trust in God will grow stronger. In the end, the believers will be perfect, or completely mature. Just like a piece of fruit is mature when it is fully developed and ready for people to use,

James 1:1–11

a person is perfect or mature when they consistently act like someone who is wise and ready to work. When a person is complete, they are whole—they have everything they need to do good work.

Stop here and discuss what words or phrases you will use for **perfect** and **complete**. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about perfect. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that if they are not wise and do not know how to live a faithful life, or they lack wisdom, they should ask God to make them wise, or to give them wisdom. Wisdom here means to understand how God wants the believers to live.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **wisdom** in this passage. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about wisdom. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that when they ask God for wisdom, they should believe, or have faith, and not doubt. To believe something is to trust something so much that you are willing to do what you believe. Doubt is the opposite of believing.

Stop here and discuss what words or phrases you will use for **believe**, or have **faith**, and for **doubt**. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about belief and faith. If you have translated doubt in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Pause this audio here.

James says that a person who doubts is double-minded. This is the first of only two places in the Bible where authors use this word. When a person is double-minded, they want to do two different things at the same time, and they do not know which thing to do. This is the opposite of loving God with an undivided, or whole, heart. When someone loves God with a whole heart, that person thinks only about God himself and what God wants that person to do. When someone is double-minded, they think about more than just what God wants them to do, and these things confuse that person so that they do not know what to do.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **double-minded**. Pause this audio here.

James tells the poor and humble believers and the wealthy believers to take pride in their positions. In the Bible, being proud is often a bad thing, but here James uses it in a good way. Here, to be proud means to rejoice, or to give glory to God.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **pride** in this passage. Pause this audio here.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 1:1–11

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (840 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.7 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.4 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

James 1:12–18

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 1:12–18 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 1:12–18 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 1:12–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous part of this letter, James said believers who trusted God through difficult times could be truly happy because difficulties made their faith strong.

In this part of James' letter, James talks again about believers who continue to trust God through difficult times. Here, James says that believers who continue to trust God through difficult times can be truly happy, because God has promised to give a "crown of life" to these believers. James is not thinking about a real crown that a king or queen wears. James is thinking about the crown of leaves that the winner of a race in Greek and Roman times wears. In ancient Greek and Roman times, races were important events at big festivals like the Olympics. People ran in a race to show that they were strong and skillful. Other people respected and honored the winners of races. People gave the winners prizes like money and wreaths that people made of leaves. People admired winners and treated them like heroes.

Stop here and look at a picture of a person giving a crown of leaves to a Greek athlete who has won a race. Pause this audio here.

James does not mean that God will give only one believer, or a small number of believers, a real crown. James is talking to all the believers who continue to trust God through difficult times. James says that God will give these people the reward of life forever with God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture or community, how do you honour or reward someone who has been brave and persevered, or continued to do the right things, through difficult times? Pause this audio here.

James has been talking about trials, or difficult situations, that believers have as they go through life. Now James talks about temptations. A temptation is when a person has an opportunity to get what they want or do what

James 1:12–18

they want, but in a way that is not good or right. Someone has a temptation when they have a very strong desire to do an evil thing. James says that God does not give the believers anything that would harm the believers, because that would be a bad thing to do, and God cannot do bad things. Therefore, God does not tempt people. Instead, people want to do bad things so much that it seems like their desire to do these bad things forces the people to do them! James says temptation is like a bait that people put in a trap to catch an animal, or onto a hook to catch a fish.

Stop here and look at pictures of a trap with bait for animals, and a fishing hook with bait to catch fish. Pause this audio here.

James goes on to say what happens when someone falls into a trap or gives in to temptation. James compares what happens to when a woman becomes pregnant and then gives birth to a baby. The baby then grows up, and when the baby is fully grown, it also gives birth. James is saying that a person's evil desires lead that person to sin, and then their sin makes them spiritually dead. When someone is spiritually dead, they are separated from God, even when they are physically alive.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Sometimes, difficult situations can make a person want to do bad things. For example, a person who is ill might want to blame God for not making the person better, or a person who does not have enough money might want to steal money from somebody else. Tell a story about a person who did bad things because that person was in a difficult situation. Pause this audio here.

James really loves and cares for the believers, so James reminds the believers that all good things come from "the Father of lights." The Father of lights is another way to talk about God, the creator of the sun and moon and other heavenly bodies, or stars. This is a title for God that James only uses in this part of his letter, and no one else uses anywhere in Scripture. James says that God does not change. James refers to the changing patterns of light and shadow, which the movement of the sun, moon, and stars causes. James contrasts the changing light and shadow with God, who does not move or change.

James finishes by reminding the believers that it is God who gives us new life. This new life happens because God wants it, not because people earn it. The new life comes because people believe the good news or true words about Jesus.

Believers have new life, so they are the "firstfruits" of creation. In the Old Testament, we hear how Israelite farmers give God the first part of their harvest as a special gift. This shows that the people thank God for the harvest and trust God for the rest of the harvest. When James says that God gives "us" new life, James could mean two things. James might be saying that Israelite believers are God's chosen people and were the first people to receive God's blessings. Or James might be talking about all the followers of Jesus and suggesting that many more people will believe later. James does not make it clear which he means, but both ideas show that God has a bigger plan that starts with some people and will grow to include many more. However, the people who were the first people in the kingdom will hold a special place of honor in the history of God's kingdom.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 1:12–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: James tells the believers that God will give a reward that lasts forever to believers who continue to trust in God through difficult times.

In the second part: James talks to the believers about temptations.

In the third part: James reminds the believers that all good things, including new life, come from God.

The characters in this passage are:

- James

- God
- The Jewish believers who are not living in or close to Jerusalem
- Some believers who receive the crown of life from God
- And some believers who are experiencing temptation

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Remember that James is in Jerusalem and is writing to believers who are living in many different places.

In the first part, James says that believers who continue to trust in God through difficult times are happy, or blessed. James means that these believers are happy, or full of joy, because they are brave when they go through difficult times without giving up. You can use the same word for being happy or joyful that you used in the previous passage.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Listen to Jesus' teaching in Matthew 5, where Jesus also says that people are blessed when they do certain things. What words did you use to translate the idea that people are "blessed" or happy in that passage? Do you like the way you translated it there? Do you need to use the same word or a different word in this passage? Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that if they continue to trust God through difficult times, God will give them a "crown of life." James is not thinking about a real crown that a king or queen wears. James is thinking about the crown of leaves that the winner of a race in Greek and Roman times wears.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What words or phrases do you use when you talk about a person who wins a race or completes a difficult task? What reward or prize do people give the winner? Talk about how you will translate the idea of receiving a "crown of life." Pause this audio here.

In the second part, James tells the believers that God does not tempt them because it is impossible for God to tempt the believers. But believers want to do evil things, and believers do these things. James talks about "difficult times" and "temptations," which are two different things. Difficult situations are when things that we cannot control happen to us and harm us. But temptations are when we are in difficult situations and really want to do something evil. If we do that evil thing, it will harm us or other people.

Stop here and discuss as a group: First, tell a story about a time when you were in a difficult situation that you had no control over. Then tell a story about a time when you were in a difficult situation and were tempted to do a bad thing. What did you do? Notice the words and phrases you use to describe the two different situations. Choose what words you will use for "difficult times" and "temptations" when you translate this passage. Pause this audio here.

Our evil desires are just like a bait or a trap that attracts an animal. We continue to want to sin until, finally, we give in and we do the sin.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Remember the story you told in step two about someone who sinned because they were in a difficult situation. Think about being in such a difficult situation when you really want to do something bad, and it is difficult not to do that bad thing. Remember the photo of the animal trap you saw in step two? How will you talk about your evil desires like bait in an animal trap that makes you want to sin? Pause this audio here.

James compares what happens when a person wants to sin to when a woman becomes pregnant. Then the woman gives birth to a baby. The birth of the baby symbolizes the person doing the sin. Then the person continues to sin, and it is like the baby grows up. When the baby fully grows up, it also gives birth to another baby. But this baby is death. In other words, James is saying that a person's evil desires lead that person to sin, and when a person continues to sin, they die spiritually and no longer have a relationship with God.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do you appropriately describe the way a woman gets pregnant and gives birth to a baby in your culture? If it is difficult to talk about a woman getting pregnant and giving birth, how will you describe how evil desires lead to sin, which leads to separation from God? Pause this audio here.

Now stop and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a person who is spiritually dead. In other words, the person is physically alive but has no relationship with God. Talk about the words and phrases you use to describe this person as being spiritually dead. Pause this audio here.

James 1:12–18

James starts the third part of this passage by using a phrase that means James wants the believers to understand clearly what James is saying.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell your group something that is very important for them to know. Pay attention to the words, phrases, and gestures you use to make sure the group knows it is important. Talk about what words, phrases, and gestures you will use when you translate this part of the passage. Pause this audio here.

James calls the believers "brothers and sisters," but James also says they are "dear" brothers and sisters. This means that James loves and cares for the believers.

Stop here and discuss as a group: You have already translated "brothers and sisters" in the previous passage. In your language, what word or phrase would you use to show that you care deeply for a group of people, even more than just calling them brothers and sisters? Pause this audio here.

James then reminds the believers that all good things come from "the Father of lights." The "Father of lights" is another name of God, who is the creator of everything, including the sun and moon and other heavenly bodies, or stars. James contrasts the changing light and shadow of the sun, moon, and heavenly bodies, which move around in the sky, with God, who does not move or change.

Stop here and do this activity: Go outside and look at the shadow of a tree or a bush. If the wind is blowing, notice how the shadow moves. If the air is still, make a mark on the ground to show where the shadow is lying. Go away, but come back later and notice that the shadow has moved. Pause this audio here.

God is not like the shadow. God does not move or change.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about the fact that God does not move like a shadow moves? Pause this audio here.

James finishes by reminding the believers that when they believe the true word, or message, from God, God chooses to give the believers a new and complete life. James says that he and these believers are like God's "firstfruits." You will remember that the firstfruits were the first and best part of the harvest that the Israelites would bring to dedicate to God. The Israelites then trusted that God would give much more harvest! Just like the firstfruits of the harvest are special to God, these believers are special to God. And God has an even bigger plan to include many more believers in his kingdom!

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about the "firstfruits" of the harvest, or the fact that the believers who believe the true message from God are like the best part of the harvest? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 1:12–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- God
- The Jewish believers who are not living in or close to Jerusalem
- Some believers who receive the crown of life from God
- And some believers who are experiencing temptation

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

James 1:12–18

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first part of this letter, James talks again about believers who continue to trust God through difficult times. Here, James says that believers who continue to trust God through difficult times can be happy, because God has promised to give a "crown of life," or eternal life, to all the believers who continue to trust God through difficult times.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who God is giving the crown of life to, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This is wonderful. Sometimes it has been difficult to trust God, but I am glad that I did; or
- Some of my family members do not have this reward from God because they did not trust God all the time. That makes me sad.

Continue the drama.

James has been talking about trials, or difficult situations that believers face as they go through life. In this second part, James starts talking about temptations. A temptation is when a person wants to do something that will harm that person or somebody else in some way. James says that God does not give the believers anything that would harm them, because that would be a bad thing to do, and God cannot do bad things. James says that when a person does what they want to do, it can result in doing bad things, and when a person continues to do bad things, it can result in spiritual death. James uses the same words he would use to describe a woman who gives birth to a baby. James is saying that a person's evil desires lead that person to sin, and sin then leads to spiritual death.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am sad that the believers think that I would tempt them to do something bad; or
- I really want the believers to trust me and to make good decisions.

Continue the drama.

James calls the believers "brothers and sisters," but James also says they are "dear" brothers and sisters. This means that James loves and cares for the believers.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing James, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I love and care for the believers so much. It makes me sad that I cannot be with the believers in person; or
- I am sending this letter to the believers, but I do not know if the believers will listen to or understand what I am saying.

Continue the drama.

James then reminds the believers that all good things come from "the Father of lights." James refers to the changing patterns of light and shadow, caused by the movement of the sun, moon, and stars. James contrasts the changing light and shadow with God, who does not move or change.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Sometimes I forget that all good things come from God; or
- It is good to be reminded that God never changes, unlike the sunlight and moonlight that are always changing.

James 1:12–18

Continue the drama.

James finishes by reminding the believers that it is God who gives new life. New life happens because God wants it, not because people earn it. Believers receive this new life when they believe the true message from God. Then these believers are like the best part of the harvest, and there is still more harvest to come!

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Sometimes I need to be reminded that my life as a believer is a gift from God and that I have done nothing to earn it; or
- It is exciting to know that we are the firstfruits and there are more believers to follow.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 1:12–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James starts this passage by telling the believers that they are blessed if they persevere, or continue to trust God in difficult times. If someone is blessed, it can sometimes mean the person is receiving a blessing from God. Here, blessed means very happy, or full of joy.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **blessed**. Bless does appear in the Master Glossary, but in this passage, it has a different meaning. Remember, you have already translated this word when you translated Jesus' teaching in Matthew 5. You could use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that they are blessed if they persevere, or continue to trust God in difficult times or in **trials**. Trials are difficult situations or challenges that test your strength, patience, or faith. If you come through the difficult situation well, you will be stronger, you will be more patient, and you will trust God more. Use the same word for trial that you used in the previous passage.

James tells the believers that the **Lord** has promised the believers a crown of life. Here, Lord refers to God. Use the same word or phrase for Lord as you have used in previous passages.

James tells believers about God's promise of a special reward called the crown of life. This is not a real crown like kings wear. Instead, it is like the leaf crown that people gave to the winners in ancient Greek and Roman races. In those races, only the first-place winner received a crown. But James says all believers who keep trusting God during hard times will get this reward. The crown of life is not a physical crown. It is a way to describe the gift of eternal life that God gives to faithful believers.

Stop here and look at a picture of a person giving a crown of leaves to a Greek athlete who has won a race. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **crown of life**. Pause this audio here.

In this passage, James talks about trials and temptations. Temptations are not just about having a strong desire to have something or an opportunity to do something. Someone has a temptation when they are in a situation to get something they want, but they would have to do something bad to get it. For example, people might want to lie or steal to get something they want. Or people may want to do something bad to someone who wronged them so that they feel like there is justice.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **temptations**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that they must not say that God is tempting them, because evil things cannot tempt God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **evil**. Look up evil in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that having evil desires can lead someone to sin. If a person has an evil desire, that person wants to do or have something that is wrong or will harm themselves or somebody else. When someone sins, they disobey God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sin**. Look up sin in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in other books of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James says that sin can lead to death. Here, death does not mean physical death, which is when you stop breathing, and your body stops working. Here, death means spiritual death, which is when you can no longer have a relationship with God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **death**. Pause this audio here.

James addresses the believers as **brothers and sisters**. Use the same word or phrase that you used for brothers and sisters in the previous passage. Here, James calls the believers "dear" brothers and sisters, or brothers and sisters whom he loves very much. This means not only that the believers are members together of God's family, but that James really cares for the believers.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about the **dear**, or loved, brothers and sisters. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that God gives them perfect gifts. Here, perfect means that anything that comes from God is complete, and pure, and without any flaws. This means that anything God gives is exactly what we need, and given with love, and reliable, because God never changes.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **perfect** in this situation. Refer to perfect in the Master Glossary for more information about a perfect thing. Pause this audio here.

James gives God the title of "Father of lights." The lights are the sun, moon, and stars. James says that God is the father of the believers because God created the believers. This is the only place in the Bible where the storytellers give God the title of "Father of lights."

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Father of lights**. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that God chose to give them birth, or new life, through the "word of truth." This new life comes because people believe in God through the good news or true message about Jesus.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **word of truth**. Look up word in the Master Glossary for more information. Pause this audio here.

James describes the believers as firstfruits. In the Old Testament, God commanded his people to bring the first and best parts of their harvest as a special gift for God. This showed that the people thanked God for the harvest and trusted God for the rest of the harvest. People sometimes use firstfruits' to describe other things that are special to God, as in this passage, where it describes the believers.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **firstfruits**. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about firstfruits. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 1:12–18

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (815 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.8 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1000 KB)

James 1:19–27

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 1:19–27 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 1:19–27 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 1:19–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

James has been writing to the believers and encouraging them to continue to trust God in difficult times. Now James tells the believers that they should not only listen to God's word, but that they should also obey God's word.

James begins by reminding the believers that not only are James and the believers all part of God's family, but that James loves and cares for the believers.

James 1:19–27

James wants to share something very important with the believers. These instructions are so important that James uses a pattern of words to help the believers remember.

James gives the believers three instructions. James tells the believers to always be ready to listen to what other people are saying. James tells the believers to take time to think about what they say before they say anything. James also tells the believers not to get angry quickly or easily. James is not talking about when people are angry in a good or righteous way. James is talking about when people are angry in a bad way. James tells the believers that the reason they should not get angry in this way is that when people are angry in a bad way, it does not help them to live the right kind of life that God wants them to live.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you were angry in a bad way. What things did you do when you were angry? Were these good things to do, or bad things? Pause this audio here.

Instead of becoming angry, which does not lead to the life that God wants us to have, James tells the believers to do something different. James tells the believers they must listen to and obey the word of God. To do this will save the believers from the results of sin. First, James tells the believers to stop doing evil things. James uses words that people can also use to describe how a person takes off dirty clothes when James tells believers to take off, or stop doing, evil things. Then James encourages the believers to accept God's word, or message. James uses words that describe a seed that someone plants in the ground so that it grows and produces fruit. God's word is like a seed that God plants in people that grows and changes how people act and think. In other words, James tells the believers that before the believers can hear and obey the word of God, the believers must stop doing all the bad things they are doing.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you had to tell a group of people to stop doing bad things. How did you feel when you told the people to stop doing these evil things? How did the people respond? Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that they are wrong if they think they can listen to God's word and not obey God. The believers must also do what God's word says. God's "word" is what God says to the believers through Scripture, through Jesus, and through the teachers in the church. James says the believers who do not obey what God's word says are like people who study carefully their faces in a mirror and then walk away from the mirror and forget what their faces looked like! A mirror was a round piece of polished metal that people used to see reflections of themselves. James contrasts the people who forget what their faces looked like with people who look carefully into the mirror and then do what they need to do. These are the believers who study God's word carefully and then do what God wants them to do. James describes this as "looking intently" into the "perfect law." The "perfect law" is completely good. This law is all the commands and instructions that God has given his people to live by, including the teachings of Jesus. When we keep sinning, it is as if we lock ourselves into a prison that we cannot escape from. But when we obey God's word, God opens the door and sets us free to live the way God wants. God blesses the person who pays close attention to what God's word says, and then does it.

Stop here and look at a picture of a mirror. Pause this audio here.

In the third part of this passage, James tells the believers that if a person cannot control what he says but thinks he is living a good life, that person is wrong. When James talks about the tongue, James is not talking about the literal tongue in a person's mouth. Instead, James is talking about the words that people say. A rein or a bridle is the ropes or leather straps on a horse's head that a person uses to control the horse. James is comparing how someone who is able to control what that person says is like a person who controls his horse.

Stop here and look at a picture of a man riding a horse and controlling the horse with a bridle. Pause this audio here.

James goes on to say that the way of life that pleases God is pure and clean, or genuine. James then lists two things that please God. Firstly, believers should take care of orphans and widows when they are suffering. An orphan usually means a child who has no parents, but here it probably means a child who has no father. Widows are women whose husbands are dead. In Jewish society, fathers and husbands looked after and cared for the family. A family that had no father or husband would need help more than others because they had no man to provide for them or to protect them.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture or community, how do people protect and look after others who need help? Who are the people who most need help? Pause this audio here.

James finishes this part of his letter by saying that the second thing that pleases God is to avoid the evil behaviour that people in this world do.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 1:19–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: James encourages the believers to listen carefully, think before they speak, and not act in an angry way. Believers instead should stop acting in an evil way and accept and do what God's Word says to do.

In the second part: James tells the believers to study God's word carefully and obey it.

In the third part: James encourages the believers to speak carefully and describes the way that God wants us to live.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers
- Believers who listen to God's word but do not obey God's word
- Believers who listen to God's word and obey it
- Orphans
- Widows
- And God

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first part, James calls the believers dear brothers and sisters for the second time. James often uses the phrase "brothers and sisters" to show that he is going to start talking about something different. Then James uses a phrase that means that what James is going to say next is important and that the believers need to understand and remember what he says. James also mentions the three themes that he is going to talk about: listening, speaking, and being angry. James uses a pattern of words that would make it easier for the believers to remember the important instructions that James gives them about these subjects. James says the believers should be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to be angry.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about when you had to say something very important to a group of people, and you wanted them to remember what you said. Notice what words, phrases, or gestures you used so that the group knew what you were saying was important and would remember what you said. Pause this audio here.

James shows the difference between how the believers should listen to people and talk to people. James says believers should be quick to listen and slow to speak. This means the believers should always be ready to listen to what other people are saying and take time to think about those things before they say anything in return. Then James tells the believers not to get angry quickly or easily. James is not talking about people being angry in a good or righteous way. James is talking about when people are angry in a bad way. When people are angry in a bad way, they often hurt other people. James tells the believers they should not get angry in this way because it does not help them to live a righteous life, or the kind of life that God wants them to live, in good relationship with him.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about being quick to listen and slow to speak. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers they must get rid of all the bad things they are doing. The words James uses for getting rid of something are the same words that people use to talk about taking off dirty clothes. James uses two words to emphasise how bad the things are that the believers are doing. James says that these actions are "dirty," or morally wrong. James even says that these actions are evil. James may have been thinking about the evil behaviour and customs that were common in the non-Jewish society around these believers at the time James was writing this letter.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about taking off or getting rid of the bad things believers are doing. Remember your discussion from step two about how you told a group of people to stop doing bad things. How will you translate this part of James' letter so that it is clear that James is strongly telling the believers to stop doing bad things? Pause this audio here.

Only when the believers take off these dirty clothes—the sins—will they have room in their lives for something new. James says the believers must humbly accept the word of God that God plants in them. God's word is like a seed that somebody plants in the ground. It needs space to grow. If the believers listen to and obey the word of God, it is like a seed that will grow and produce right behavior, like a seed produces fruit. God's word, when people follow it, saves them!

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe people accepting the word of God that God plants in them. Pause this audio here.

In the second part, James tells the believers that they are wrong if they think they can listen to God's word and not obey it. The believers must also do what God's word says. God's "word" here is what God says to the believers through Scripture, through Jesus, and through the teachers in the church. James says these believers who do not obey God's word are like people who look in a mirror and maybe see dirt on their face, and then walk away from the mirror and forget to wash the dirt off. A mirror was a round piece of polished metal that people used to see reflections of themselves. James contrasts the people who walk away from the mirror and forget with people who look carefully into the mirror and then do what they need to do. Those who look in the mirror and do what they need to do are like the believers who study God's word carefully and then do what God wants them to do. James describes this kind of action as "looking intently" into the "perfect law." The perfect law is completely good. This law means all the commands and instructions that God has given his people to live by, including the teachings of Jesus. When we keep sinning, it is as if we lock ourselves into a prison that we cannot escape from. But when we obey God's word, God opens the door and sets us free to live the way God wants. God blesses the person who pays close attention to what God's word says and then does it.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when you gave instructions to two groups of people. One group listened to the instructions and then did the task that you had given them. The other group listened to the instructions but did not do the task you had given them. Pay attention to the words, phrases, and gestures you use when you are talking about the two groups of people. How will this help you translate what James says about listening to the word of God and then doing what God wants? Pause this audio here.

In the third part, James tells the believers that if a person cannot control what he says but thinks he is living a good life, he is wrong. That person's life is worthless because he is not living as God wants him to live. James uses the picture of a person's tongue to show what he means. The tongue represents the words that people speak. A person who cannot control what he says is someone who is not wise when he uses words. That person may use words to tell lies, to make people sad, or to cause trouble. James is saying that a person who is able to control what that person says is like a person who controls his horse by pulling on the reins.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about someone who does not control what he says, a person who causes trouble and says unwise words. Pay attention to the gestures, words, and phrases you use when you are talking about this person. Talk about how you will translate this part of James' letter. Pause this audio here.

James goes on to say that religion, or the way we live and worship God, should be pure and clean. If a person lives purely, that means that they are totally devoted to do whatever God asks that person to do. Similarly, if a person lives cleanly, they live in a sincere way that pleases God. James lists two things that please God. Firstly, James says it pleases God when believers take care of other people in the community who have nobody to look after them, like widows and orphans. Secondly, James says that it pleases God when believers live in a way that is different from the other people in the world who do bad things. James uses words that compare the good way

believers live to the way a person keeps their clothes or bodies clean, or makes sure that their clothes or bodies do not have dirty spots.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe the way believers live and worship God as pure and clean. Also, discuss how you will talk about acting differently from how people in the world act. Will you use words that compare the way believers act to staying clean? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it. You may want to use people or objects to show James, God, and the different groups of believers. You may want to have the different groups of believers stand in different parts of the space where you are to show that the believers lived in many different places. There are several contrasting ideas in this passage. For example: being ready to listen or being quick to get angry, just listening to God's word or listening to God's word and doing it, seeing your dirty face in a mirror and taking the dirt off or seeing your dirty face in a mirror and then walking away. As you retell the story, you may want to have some people do the "good action" and others do the "bad action."

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 1:19–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers
- Believers who listen to God's word but do not obey God's word
- Believers who listen to God's word and obey it
- Orphans
- Widows
- And God

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first part, James calls the believers dear brothers and sisters. James tells the believers to always be ready to listen to what other people are saying. James tells the believers to take time to think about what those people say before the believers say anything in return. James also tells the believers not to get angry quickly or easily. James tells the believers that the reason they should not get angry in this bad way is that it does not help them to live the right kind of life that God wants them to live.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing James, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- What I am saying to the believers is really important. I would like to tell the believers myself, but I cannot be with them all. I have to trust that the person reading this letter to the believers understands that this is important for the believers to hear; or

- I hope I am saying this in the right way. I do not want the believers to think I am angry with them.

Continue the drama.

James says that if the believers want the right kind of life, they should get rid of all the evil in their lives. Then the believers can accept and follow God's Word that God has planted in their hearts, like a person plants a seed. God's Word is powerful. When the believers follow God's Word, it saves the believers' lives.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I understand James is telling us to stop doing bad things, but sometimes it is very hard to be different from the people around me; or
- When James writes about this, I can see that what I have been doing is wrong, but I want to be different.

Continue the drama.

In the second part, James describes two groups of believers. Firstly, James talks about the believers who are mistaken because they think they can listen to God's word and not follow it. The second group of believers is those who pay careful attention to what God's word says, and then do what God wants them to do. James says that God blesses the person who pays close attention to what God's word says and then does it.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who are listening but not doing what God wants them to do, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel really bad. I think James is talking about me. Somebody must have told James that I am not following God's word; or
- I wish James would not say these things to us. James does not understand what it is like to be a believer in my situation.

Continue the drama.

In the third part, James tells the believers that if a person cannot control what he says, but thinks he is living a good life, he is mistaken. A person who cannot control what he says is someone who is not wise when he uses words. That person uses words to tell lies, to make people sad, or to cause trouble. James is saying that a person who is able to control what that person says is like a person who controls his horse with a rein.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am sad. I think I have been living a good life, and I thought God was pleased with me, but now I understand that I have not been careful about what I say. I did not realize that what I say is very important to God; or
- I see now there are many areas of my life where God is not pleased with me. I need to spend more time finding out what God wants me to do and doing it.

Continue the drama.

James goes on to say that the way of life that pleases God is pure, clean, and genuine. James lists two things that please God. Firstly, to take care of people in the community who have nobody to look after them, and secondly, not to behave like the evil people in this world.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I can think of people in my community who the community is not looking after. I know I must do something to help those people; or

James 1:19–27

- I am glad that God has told James to remind us not to behave like the evil people in this world. I needed to hear it again.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 1:19–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James addresses the believers as **dear brothers and sisters**. Use the same phrase that you used for dear brothers and sisters in the previous passage.

James tells the believers that when they are angry in a human or bad way, they cannot live in a way that pleases God. When people are angry in a bad or human way, it is a strong emotion and is often a reaction to a situation where a person feels threatened or hurt. For this reason, when a person is angry, they can damage things and hurt people. When a person is angry like this, that person is selfish, and nothing good happens. When a person is angry in a selfish way, it is different from when God is angry, because when God is angry, God is getting rid of sin and evil, and God's anger produces good things.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **human anger** in this passage. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that when people are angry, it does not produce the righteousness that God wants from his people. Here, James means the right behaviour or actions that God wants from God's people. These right actions cause us to have a good relationship with God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **righteousness**. Look up righteousness in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The believers must get rid of dirt and wickedness. James uses dirt to represent the bad and wicked things that people do. Wickedness means the same as evil. Evil is the opposite of good.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **wickedness**. Look up wickedness in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that they must listen to the **word** and also do what it says. God's "word" here is what God says to the believers through Scripture, through Jesus, and through the teachers in the church. Use the same word that you have used in previous passages for word, and refer to the Master Glossary for more information.

God's word saves the believers' souls. When people use the word soul, they sometimes mean the invisible part of a person where a person thinks, feels, and wants things. Here, James uses the word soul to refer to the whole person.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **soul**. Look up soul in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James says that listening to God's word is like looking into a mirror. A mirror was a round piece of polished metal that people used to see reflections of themselves.

Stop here and look at a picture of a **mirror**. Then discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for mirror. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that they must study God's law carefully because God's **perfect** law gives freedom. A law is a rule or a set of rules that people have to keep. God's laws are the set of instructions and commands that God gave to the Jewish people and then to the believers. God's perfect law is completely good and has everything in it that we need. Use the same word or phrase for perfect as you have previously, and refer to perfect in the Master Glossary for more information. When people obey God's law, it frees those people from wanting

James 1:19–27

to disobey God and makes it possible for them to do what God wants them to do. Sin no longer has control of people when they are free.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for God's perfect **law** and for **freedom**. Look up law in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

When believers follow God's perfect law, God blesses the believers. When God blesses someone, God shows that person favor and does good things for them.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **bless**. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about bless. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers they need to control what they say in the same way that a person controls a horse with a rein or bridle. A rein or a bridle is the ropes or leather straps on a horse's head that a person uses to control the horse.

Stop here and look at a picture of a **rein** or **bridle**. Then discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for a rein or bridle. Pause this audio here.

James says that the religion that pleases God is pure and clean, or without fault. Religion is a system of belief and faith, or a way that people regularly worship God and what they believe about God. This religion that pleases God is the way that believers trust in Jesus and live as God's people. Something that is pure is not mixed. Something that is pure has only good things in it, not several good and bad things that people mix together.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **religion** and **pure**. Look up pure in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

When James says that believers should not allow the world to make them dirty, James is saying that believers should not allow the evil actions that non-believers in the world do to influence believers to do evil things.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe "**the world**."

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 1:19–27

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (812 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.2 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

James 2:1–7

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 2:1–7 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 2:1–7 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 2:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

James begins this part of his letter by again calling the believers brothers and sisters. James wants to again remind the believers that they are all members together of God's family. Then James makes a strong statement and follows it up with a story to show what James means. James says that people who believe in Jesus must not honour some people more than others. The title that James gives Jesus is "our glorious Lord Jesus Christ." When something or someone is glorious or full of glory, they are majestic and wonderful. James is reminding the believers that Jesus is now with God and that Jesus is glorious because God is glorious! If we believe in Jesus like this, then we should never disrespect anyone!

James tells a story to help the believers understand what James means. James tells a story about a rich man and a poor man who both come into a meeting. It is not clear what sort of meeting this is, but it is most likely a gathering of believers. Although James is just telling a story, it is likely that James is thinking of real situations that he has seen or heard. In the story, the rich man has a gold ring and beautiful clothes. These items had high value in that culture, so the believers know that this man is rich and that the people in the community respect the rich man. In the story, the other man is wearing old and dirty clothes. The believers know that this man is poor and has no possessions, and that the people in the community do not respect the poor man.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a person in your community or culture who is important. What makes this person important? If you met this person for the first time, how would you know, by looking at them, that they are important? Tell another story about a person in your community or culture who is unimportant. What makes this person unimportant? If you met this person for the first time, how would you know they are unimportant? For example, it might be because they wear the same clothes every day, or because they have to walk everywhere. Pause this audio here.

James 2:1–7

In the story, the believers see the rich man and honour him. The believers care about the man and are interested in him. The believers offer the man a seat of honour. In the story, when the believers see the poor man, they tell him he must stand up or sit on the floor. At the time when James lived, important people would sit on a fine chair with a low stool in front of it. The important people would rest their feet on this stool. People called this a footstool. Poor people would sit on the floor below the level of the rich person's feet on the footstool. When the believers tell the man to stand or sit on the floor, this means that they do not respect or honour him.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about an important person in your community, and an unimportant person in your community. How do people in the community welcome these people when the community meets together? How do people act towards the important person and the unimportant person? Is it difficult to act towards them in the same way? Pause this audio here.

James finishes the story by asking the believers a question. James asks, "Is it true that the way you have unfairly judged people shows that you have evil motives?" James is not asking for information and is not expecting the believers to answer the question. James is using this sort of question to emphasise what James is saying. James wants the believers to understand that it is wrong to honour somebody because they have wealth and possessions, and it is wrong to dishonour somebody because they do not have wealth or possessions. When the believers make these decisions, they are thinking the believers can decide who is worthy of honour. These believers do not have the authority to judge, and the believers judge with the wrong motives. Only God can judge people fairly, and only God has the authority to do so.

First, James told a story to show that it was wrong to honour rich people over poor people. Now, James gives the believers two reasons why it is wrong to honour rich people over poor people.

James tells the believers something really important. James again calls the believers brothers and sisters and asks the believers another question. James asks, "Is it true that God chose the poor in this world to strongly believe in God? Is it true that the poor people are the people who will inherit the kingdom God promised to those who love God?" Again, James is not asking for information and is not expecting the believers to answer the question. James is using this sort of question to emphasise what James is saying. James wants the believers to remember that God chooses people who seem unimportant in the world. When these poor and unimportant people believe in Jesus, they become spiritually rich because when they trust in Jesus, God sees them as valuable people. God will bless those people because God has promised that he will make everyone who trusts in God a citizen in God's kingdom. James is not saying that all poor and unimportant people are spiritually rich. James means that poor people who trust in God are spiritually rich. James may also be wanting the believers to remember that Jesus often talked about poor people receiving God's kingdom, or becoming citizens of God's kingdom.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Think about some unimportant believers whom the community does not value, perhaps because they are poor. But these unimportant people are also believers, and they are also going to be citizens in God's kingdom with you. How do you feel knowing that these people will live with you forever in God's kingdom? Pause this audio here.

Now James contrasts what the believers usually do with what God does. God chooses and honors the people who seem unimportant. The believers dishonour the people who seem unimportant.

James finishes by asking three more questions that James does not expect anyone to answer. James is reminding the believers of what they already know. James reminds the believers that it is the rich and important people in the community who are treating the believers badly, using their power against the believers, and making the believers suffer. James reminds the believers that the rich people are making false accusations against the believers and forcing them to go to court. To take someone to court means to take someone to a judge and ask the judge to say that you are right and the other person is wrong. A person does this so that the judge will punish the other person. James reminds the believers that the rich people are blaspheming, or insulting, the name of Jesus. James wants the believers to understand that just because a person is rich, it does not mean that person is good!

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 2:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: James tells the believers that they must not honour some people more than other people.

In the second part: James tells a story to help the believers understand what James means.

In the third part: James gives the believers two more reasons why they must not honour some people more than other people.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers
- Jesus Christ
- A man who is dressed in beautiful clothes
- A man who is dressed in dirty clothes
- And God

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first part, James calls the believers brothers and sisters. James is reminding the believers again that they are all members together of God's family. Then James says that people who believe in "our glorious Lord Jesus Christ" must not honour some people more than others. When James uses "our," he means that James and the believers believe in the same Lord Jesus Christ. James describes Jesus as "glorious" because Jesus is now in heaven with God.

In the second part, James tells a story to help the believers understand what James means. In the story, a rich man and a poor man both come into a meeting. It is not clear what sort of meeting it is, but it is most likely a gathering of believers. In the story, the rich man has a gold ring and beautiful, expensive clothes. These items had high value in that culture, so the believers know the man is rich and the people in the community respect him. In the story, the other man is wearing old and dirty clothes. The believers know that this man is poor and has no possessions and that people in the community do not respect him. In the story, the believers offer the rich man a seat of honour, or the most important seat in the gathering.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what is the honorable seat or the best and most important place to sit? What do you call this place? Discuss how you want to translate the idea of a seat of honor. Pause this audio here.

In the story, when the believers see the poor man, they tell the man he must stand up or sit on the floor. At the time when James lived, important people would sit on a fine chair with a low stool in front of it. The important people would rest their feet on this stool. This was called a footstool. Poor people would sit on the floor below the level of the rich person's feet on the footstool. When the believers tell the man to stand or sit on the floor, this means that the believers do not respect or honour the man.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what is the least honorable seat or worst place to sit? What would people think about a seat that is next to or below someone else's feet? Discuss how you want to describe the way the poor people have to sit on the floor next to a footstool. Pause this audio here.

James finishes the story when James asks if the believers are creating differences between people and becoming judges with evil motives. James does not expect anyone to answer this question. James is using this sort of question to emphasise what James is saying. James wants the believers to understand that it is wrong to honour somebody because they have wealth and possessions, and it is wrong to dishonour somebody because they do not have wealth or possessions. When the believers do this, they think that the believers can decide who is worthy of honour. The believers act like judges, who decide if a person has acted in a right or wrong way. Some judges are evil, and so they do not judge fairly. These believers are becoming just like judges with evil motives when the believers decide to honor one person more than another person.

James 2:1–7

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when you wanted a group of people to understand something. You decided to tell the people a story to help them understand what you were saying. Why did you tell the people a story? Pay attention to the gestures, words, and phrases that you used when you told the story. How will you tell this story about the rich man and the poor man who came into the meeting? Pause this audio here.

James starts the third part with a word that tells the believers that they need to listen and pay special attention to what James is about to say. James calls the believers dear brothers and sisters again to remind them that he is writing to them as a brother and that he cares for them and loves them. James really wants the believers to understand what James is saying.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when you wanted a group of people to pay special attention to what you were going to say. What gestures, words, and phrases did you use to make sure they were listening to you? Pause this audio here.

James asks the believers another question. James asks if it is true that God has chosen the people who are poor or unimportant in this world to be important in God's kingdom. Again, James is not asking for information and is not expecting the believers to answer the question. James is using this sort of question to emphasise what he is saying.

Now, James wants the believers to remember that God chooses people to be a part of his kingdom who seem unimportant in the world. When these poor and unimportant people believe in Jesus, they become spiritually rich because the way they trust in Jesus gives the believers value. God will bless these people, and God has promised that everybody who trusts in God will inherit the kingdom of God. The kingdom of God does not refer to a country on Earth. This kingdom is everywhere God rules. In this kingdom, people belong to God, obey God, and live in a right relationship with God. All things belong to God, and God shares good things with believers, both now and in the future. The believers inherit or receive these good things when they inherit the kingdom of God.

Stop here and discuss how you will describe being "rich in faith," or "spiritually rich." How will you describe that the believers are spiritually rich because they inherit the kingdom of God? In your language, how do you talk about the way that someone is rich or has a lot of something good, but that good thing is not something you can touch, like money? In other words, someone is "rich" when they have a good relationship with God and others. Pause this audio here.

James is not saying that all poor and unimportant people are rich in faith, but only those poor people who love God. James may also be wanting the believers to remember what Jesus said in Matthew 5: "God blesses the poor in spirit, who are those who know that they need God, because God has given those people the ability to become citizens of God's kingdom."

James starts the next part with a word that contrasts what God does and what the believers do. God chooses the people who seem unimportant to be in God's kingdom. But the believers dishonour the people who seem unimportant.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about two people who did different things. Think of a moment when one person acted in one way, and the other person acted in a completely different way. As you tell your story, notice the gestures, words, and phrases you use when you are drawing attention to the difference between the actions. Pause this audio here.

James finishes by asking three more questions that James does not expect anyone to answer. James is reminding the believers of what they already know. James reminds the believers that it is the rich and important people in the community who are treating the believers badly. The rich people in the community use their power against the believers and make the believers suffer. James reminds the believers that the rich people are making false accusations against the believers and forcing them to go to court. James reminds the believers that the rich people are blaspheming, or insulting, the honorable name. But this is the name, or person, to whom the believers belong! Though James does not say which name this is, this name is probably Jesus's name. When Jesus calls a name over someone, it means that this person becomes Jesus' possession and has a special relationship to Jesus. In that time, a person's name was also closely related to their reputation. If someone insulted a person's

James 2:1–7

name, they insulted that person's reputation and character. So James means that when the rich people insulted the believers who belonged to Jesus, those people also insulted Jesus.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kind of family names do you have, or what names do you share with other members of your family or tribe? If someone insults or dishonors you, how does your family feel about that? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you were talking to a group of people and had to tell those people something they already knew. What gestures, words, and phrases do you use when you are telling somebody something that they already know? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it. You may want to use people or objects to show James, God, and the different groups of believers. You may want to have the different groups of believers stand in different parts of the space where you are to show that the believers lived in many different places. As you retell the story, you may want to have the rich man and the poor man come into one of the groups of believers. You can have another believer offer the rich man a chair to sit on and tell the poor man to sit on the floor.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 2:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers
- Jesus Christ
- A man who is dressed in beautiful clothes
- A man who is dressed in dirty clothes
- And God

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first part, James calls the believers brothers and sisters. Then James says that people who believe in "our glorious Lord Jesus Christ" must not honour some people more than others.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not understand why James is saying this to us. Our community of believers is open to everyone; or
- I am glad that James is saying this. When I became a believer, I did not feel like the other believers welcomed me.

James 2:1–7

Continue the drama.

In the second part, James tells a story to help the believers understand what James means.

Remember, this is a story that James is telling to the believers. This story is not really happening, but it is important for you to act out the story.

In the story, a rich man and a poor man both come into a meeting, probably a gathering of believers. In the story, the rich man has a gold ring and beautiful clothes. In the story, the other man is wearing old and dirty clothes. The believers who are in the meeting show honour to the rich man and offer him a seat. But the believers who are in the meeting show disrespect to the poor man. The believers tell the poor man he must stand up or sit on the floor. James asks if the believers are creating differences among people and becoming judges with evil motives. But James already knows that this is what the believers are doing. James wants the believers to understand that it is wrong to honour somebody because they have wealth and possessions, and it is wrong to dishonour somebody because they do not have wealth or possessions.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the rich man, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- It is right that the other believers gave me a good seat in the meeting, where people can see me; or
- I feel bad that the other believers have given me a good seat. The poor man who came into the meeting at the same time as me has to sit on the floor. We are both believers. I think people should treat us in the same way.

Ask the person playing the believers who are watching the story, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel bad. This reminds me of what has happened in some of our meetings; or
- It is not right that the poor man has to sit on the floor. The poor man should be allowed to sit down next to the rich man.

Continue the drama.

James says, "Listen to what I will say, dear brothers and sisters!"

James asks if it is true that God has chosen the unimportant people to have faith, which is truly valuable, and to be citizens of God's kingdom. This is certainly true!

However, while God chooses the people who seem unimportant, the believers dishonour the people who seem unimportant!

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- It makes me sad when I see the believers acting in a disrespectful way towards the people that the community thinks are unimportant. I created those people, and I care about those people. I want the believers to value those people like I do; or
- It makes me angry when I see the believers acting in a disrespectful way towards the people that the community thinks are unimportant.

Continue the drama.

James reminds the believers that it is the rich and important people in the community who are treating the believers badly, using their power against the believers and making the believers suffer. James reminds the believers that the rich people are making false accusations against the believers and taking them to court. James reminds the believers that the rich people are blaspheming, or insulting, the name of God.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 2:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

James 2:1–7

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James addresses the believers as **brothers and sisters** and **dear brothers and sisters**. Use the same words or phrases that you used for “brothers and sisters” and “dear brothers and sisters” as you have in a previous passage.

James says that believers in our glorious Lord Jesus Christ must not show favouritism. “Lord” is a title of respect and shows that Jesus has authority and power. “Jesus” is his human name. “Christ” is the Greek word for Messiah or Annointed One. To describe Jesus as “glorious” means that he is wonderful and majestic, just like God is!

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the title “glorious Lord Jesus Christ.” Look up glory, Lord, and Christ in the Master Glossary for more information. Translate Lord and Christ in the same way you have previously. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers they must not show favoritism. Another way to say this is to say that the believers must not honour some people more than others.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for showing **favoritism** or honoring someone. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, translate this idea in a similar way. Pause this audio here.

James tells a story about a rich man and a poor man who both come into a meeting. Although James is just telling a story, it is likely that James is thinking of real situations that he has seen or heard. In the story, the man has a gold ring and beautiful and expensive clothes. These items had high value in that culture, so the believers know the man is rich and the people in the community respect him. In the story, the other man is wearing old and dirty clothes. The believers know that this man is poor and has no possessions, and people in the community do not respect him.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use when you describe the rich man and the poor man and how people treat them. Pause this audio here.

James says that the believers act like judges with **evil** motives. Evil is the opposite of good. A judge is someone who has the authority to decide if a person’s actions are right or wrong. A judge will punish the person if the judge decides that the person is guilty of doing wrong. These believers make decisions about others as if these believers have authority to do so. But these believers make the decisions with evil or bad motives! For more information on evil, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word for evil that you used in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **judge**. Look up judge in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that God has chosen those whom the world sees as unimportant to be rich in **faith**. If you believe in someone or have faith, you believe that what that person says about himself is true. You then trust that person and are committed to do what that person tells you to do. Here, James is talking about having faith in God. For more information on faith, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word for faith that you used in previous passages.

James says that having faith makes a person rich because they will inherit the kingdom that God has promised to give them. A kingdom is an area that a king rules. Here, James is talking about the kingdom of heaven, or the kingdom of God, where God rules.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **kingdom**. Look up kingdom of God in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The rich people take the believers to court. To take someone to court means to take someone to a judge and ask the judge to say that you are right and the other person is wrong. A person does this so that the judge will punish the other person.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about taking someone to **court**. Pause this audio here.

James talks about the rich people who are blaspheming the name of God. This means that the rich people are insulting the name of God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use **blaspheming**. Look up blasphemy in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 2:1–7

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (882 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.6 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.2 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.3 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

James 2:8–13

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 2:8–13 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 2:8–13 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.

4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 2:8–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous part of James' letter, James told the believers that they must not honour some people more than others. In this part of his letter, James tells the believers that if they honour some people more than others, they are breaking God's law.

James tells the believers that God's royal law in Scripture says "love your neighbour as yourself." James calls God's law "the royal law" because it comes from God, who is the most important king! James also says the law comes from Scripture. When James talks about Scripture, James is referring to God's words that people had written down in the Old Testament. Old Testament law was the law for the people of Israel, and the people of Israel believed that their neighbors were people who were part of the same community as them. You will remember that in the book of Luke, however, Jesus shows that we should love even more people than we thought we should! In Luke, we hear that a man asked Jesus to explain to him who his neighbors were. Jesus told that man a story about one man who helped an injured man, even though the two men were from different people groups who hated each other. Jesus told this story to explain that everybody we meet is our neighbour. The story that Jesus told shows that we should love everybody we come into contact with, regardless of their background or social status. When we love somebody, we choose to do kind things for that person, respect them, and look after their physical needs. James tells the believers that if they are obeying this law to love their neighbor as they love themselves, they are doing the right thing.

Stop here and listen to your translation of Luke 10:25–37, where Jesus tells the story of the good neighbor. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a group of people whom your community does not accept. Why does your community not accept these people? How does your community treat these people? Do these people have to live in a different place, or are there places these people are not allowed to go? Pause this audio here.

Then James talks about the people who break this law by showing favouritism, or honoring some people more than other people. James talks about people who show favoritism in the same way he talks about a criminal in a courtroom. James describes the people who show favoritism as if they are in court, where the authorities accuse those people of doing something wrong. James describes the law as if it were the judge in the courtroom. This judge—the law—looks at the actions of those people who show favoritism and decides they are guilty of breaking the law.

James then says that if you only disobey one of God's laws, it is the same as disobeying all of God's laws. All of God's laws are important, and God expects his people to obey all of his laws. If someone disobeys even one of God's laws, they are still guilty! Then James gives an example: If someone commits murder but never commits adultery, that person is still a lawbreaker because God told us not to murder and not to commit adultery. You will remember that someone who commits murder makes a plan to kill someone and then kills that person. And you will remember that a person who commits adultery has a sexual relationship with somebody who is not that person's husband or wife.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about somebody who keeps most, but not all, of the community's rules. Then tell a story about a person who breaks many of the community's rules. Do you punish these people differently because one has broken only one law, and the other has broken many laws? How does your community treat someone who breaks one rule differently from someone who breaks many rules? Why? Pause this audio here.

In an earlier part of his letter, James reminded the believers that God wants them to obey the law that gives people freedom, or sets people free from sin. This is God's law that he gave his people, and it includes the teachings of Jesus. This perfect, or complete, law releases us to obey God's laws completely. This is good news,

and this makes believers want to completely obey God's laws! Now James reminds the believers about this law. When the believers remember to obey this law, they will speak and act in the way Jesus taught people to live. When the believers do, they will show mercy, or kindness, to people around them. The law that sets people free helps people want to do good things because they love God, not because they are afraid of being punished. When people live like this, they forgive each other, and they are kind or have mercy for one another. This law that gives freedom is the law that God will use to decide whether people are innocent or guilty. So believers should follow this law, and they should show mercy to others.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, what rules do people follow because they are frightened of what will happen to them if they do not follow the rules? How do people feel about these rules? How would your community be different if people did good things because they wanted to, not because they had to? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, what rules cause people to feel free and happy when they follow those rules? How do those rules help people treat other people with kindness? Pause this audio here.

James finishes this part of his letter with a warning and an encouragement. On the day at the end of this world when God decides whether people are innocent or guilty, God will not show mercy toward the people who have not shown mercy to other people. James does not say this, but James strongly suggests that God will show mercy to the people who have shown mercy to other people. If a person shows mercy to other people, it means the person chooses to say and do kind things to people who need kind words or actions but who may not deserve them. It is like the person who says and does kind things to people has won against an enemy! That person is not afraid that God will judge him to be wrong.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 2:8–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four parts.

In the first part: James tells the believers they are doing the right thing if they are keeping the law "to love your neighbour as yourself."

In the second part: James tells the believers that if they are showing favouritism, or honoring some people more than others, they are breaking God's law.

In the third part: James tells the believers to obey the law that gives freedom.

In the fourth part: James gives the believers a warning.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- Believers who honour some believers more than others
- Believers who break one law, but not all of them
- Believers who show mercy
- Believers who do not show mercy
- And God

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first part, James tells the believers they are doing the right thing if they keep the royal law. A royal law is a law that a king gives. God rules as king over all people, and God gave this law: "to love your neighbour as yourself."

James 2:8–13

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, what do you call a law that a king or the highest ruler gives? How important is that kind of law? Then discuss as a group how you will translate “royal law” here. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and tell a story about a person who is your neighbor. Pay attention to how you talk about that person and what you call them. Then discuss how you want to translate the way that God has said to love your neighbor in the same way you love yourself. You may listen to your translation of Luke 10:27 to hear how you translated it there. Pause this audio here.

So the believers should show love to everybody they meet. To love somebody means we choose to do kind things for people, and respect people, and look after their physical needs. We do these things for ourselves, and we should love each other in the same way! James tells the believers that if they are “keeping” or obeying this law, they are doing the right thing.

In the second part, James talks about the believers who do not follow this law. These people honor some people more than others, or show favouritism. James compares the person who shows favoritism to someone on trial in a courtroom. James describes the law as if it were a judge in the courtroom. The judge—or the law—looks at the actions of those who show favoritism and decides they are guilty of breaking the law.

Stop here and tell a story about a person who had to go to a judge, and the judge decided that the person was guilty, or had broken a law. What words or phrases do you have for the way that a judge decides that someone is guilty of breaking a law? Discuss how you want to translate the way that the law is like a judge that decides people are guilty. Pause this audio here.

James then says that if you only disobey one of God’s laws, it is the same as disobeying all of God’s laws. James uses special language to describe the way a person disobeys God’s laws. James says that the person stumbles or almost falls down. If that person stumbles, or disobeys, just one law, they are still guilty, which means that they are still a person who breaks God’s law! Then James gives an example: if someone commits murder but never commits adultery, he is still a lawbreaker.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe the special language that someone stumbles over, or disobeys, one law. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe that when a person disobeys one law, it is the same as if they disobey the entire law. That person is still a guilty person, even if they break just one law! Pause this audio here.

In the third part, James tells the believers that they must speak and act like people who know that God will use the law that gives freedom to decide whether people are innocent or guilty. When James talks about the law that sets people free, James means that when people follow what Jesus taught them, they have a new way of living. This is even better than the old rules people used to follow. James calls it the “law of freedom, or liberty” because it frees people from feeling like they cannot stop doing bad things. The law that sets people free helps people want to do good things because they love God, not because they are afraid that God will punish them. This new law teaches people to love God and be kind to others. When people live like this, they forgive each other, and they are kind to each other. In other words, these people show mercy to each other.

Stop here and remember your discussion from step two about rules that make people feel free and happy. Discuss how you want to translate “the law that gives people freedom.” James still calls this law by the same name—a “law”—but this “law” brings freedom, not judgment. Pause this audio here.

In the fourth part, James gives the believers a warning. James warns the believers that on the day when God decides whether people are innocent or guilty, God will not show mercy toward the people who have not shown mercy to other people. James does not say, but implies, that God will show mercy to the people who have shown mercy to other people. If a person shows mercy to other people, it means the person chooses to say and do kind things to people who need kind words or actions but who may not deserve them. James then says that mercy is victorious, or wins, over judgment. James talks about mercy like it were a person who defeats another person. James means that the person who shows mercy to people is not afraid that God will condemn him.

James 2:8–13

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it. You may want to have different objects or people to represent James, the believers, and God. You may want to have some of the believers honouring some believers more than others. You can choose a group of items, such as sticks, to represent the commands in the law. Someone can carry these items to represent the way that someone obeys the law. But then have that person pretend to trip and drop one of those items to represent the way a person stumbles and disobeys one of the laws. You may want to show some believers showing mercy, or kindness, to other believers, and other believers not showing mercy to other believers. You may want to show God judging the believers in the same way that they have treated the other believers.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 2:8–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- Believers who honour some believers more than others
- Believers who break one law, but not all of them
- Believers who show mercy
- Believers who do not show mercy
- And God

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first part, James tells the believers they are doing the right thing if they are keeping the royal law “to love your neighbour as yourself.” James tells the believers that if they are “keeping” or obeying this law, they are doing the right thing.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who are keeping the law, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel very proud of myself. I am doing good things for people who do not deserve them; or
- I am glad that I can show love to other people in the same way that Jesus has shown his love for us.

Continue the drama.

In the second part, James talks about the believers who honor some people more than others, or show favoritism. When these people show favoritism, these people sin. The law shows that these people have disobeyed the law.

James then says that if you only disobey one of God’s laws, it is the same as disobeying all of God’s laws. Then James gives an example: if someone commits murder but never commits adultery, he is still a lawbreaker because God told us not to murder and not to commit adultery.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who have only broken one rule, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am angry that people say that I am a lawbreaker. I am a good person. I have only done a few things wrong. I am not like those people who have broken lots of rules; or
- I am ashamed. I did not understand that if I broke one law, then I am as guilty as the person who has broken lots of laws.

Continue the drama.

In the third part, James tells the believers that they must speak and act like people who know that one day God will decide if the believers are innocent or guilty. God will decide using the law that sets the believers free from sin.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing James, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am so glad that I can remind the believers about the good news that God judges believers by the law of freedom, and not by the old law; or
- I am sad that I cannot be with the believers when they hear this letter I am writing to them. I would like to remind them of this good news in person.

Continue the drama.

In the fourth part, James warns the believers that on that day when God decides whether people are innocent or guilty, God will not show mercy toward the people who have not shown mercy to other people. The person who says and does kind things to people is not afraid that God will condemn him, because mercy is stronger than judgement.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who have shown mercy to other people, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Sometimes it is hard to show mercy to people, but I remember that God has shown mercy to me, so I want to show mercy to other people; or
- It gives me joy to know that because I show mercy to people, God will continue to show mercy to me.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 2:8–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James tells the believers to keep the royal **law** that is in Scripture. It is called the royal law because royal refers to things that come from kings. This law comes from God, who is the most important king of everything. Use the same word or phrase for law as you have used in previous passages. Refer to law in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate the special phrase for **royal law**. Pause this audio here.

James also says the law comes from Scripture. Here, “Scripture” means God’s words that people have written down in the Old Testament.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Scripture**. Look up scriptures in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James is talking to the believers about the law that says to “love your neighbor as yourself.” People usually thought of a neighbor as someone who lived in the same community as they did.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **neighbor**. Look up neighbor in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James 2:8–13

James says that people **sin** when they show favoritism. When people sin, they disobey God and rebel against God. Use the same word or phrase for sin as you have used previously, and refer to sin in the Master Glossary for more information.

If someone stumbles and disobeys a law, that person is guilty of breaking all of the law. Someone who is guilty has sinned or disobeyed God. That person deserves for God to punish them.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **guilty**. For more information about guilt, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

James talks to the believers about the **law that gives freedom**. James is talking about the new way of living that Jesus taught. This is different from the old rules people used to follow. James calls it the law that gives freedom, or the law of liberty, because it frees people from feeling like they cannot stop doing bad things. Sin no longer has control of these people. Use the same word or phrase for "law that gives freedom" that you used in previous passages.

James uses a person who murders but does not commit adultery as an example. To murder someone means to make a plan to kill someone and then do so, often secretly, so that no one will stop you. In this case, adultery refers to when people have a sexual relationship with someone to whom they are not married.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **murder** and **adultery**. Look up adultery in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James finishes this passage by talking about what will happen to people who do not show mercy to other people. If a person shows mercy to other people, it means the person chooses to say and do kind things to people who need kind words or actions but who may not deserve them.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **mercy**. Look up mercy in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that God will judge and not show mercy to people who do not show mercy to other people. When a person judges someone else, it means that they decide whether that person is guilty or innocent of doing a wrong thing.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **judge** and **judgment**. Look up judge in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 2:8–13

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (891 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.8 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

James 2:14–26

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 2:14–26 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 2:14–26 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 2:14–26 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, James told the believers that if they honour some people more than others, they are breaking God's law. Now James makes it clear to the believers that if a person has real faith in Jesus, that person will not only believe in Jesus but also do good actions.

James starts this part of his letter by emphasizing that the believers should already know and understand that if a person says they believe in Jesus, but they do not also do good actions, that kind of faith is useless. The believers should also know that God will not save a person who has faith like that. James gives an example of a believer who says kind words, but does not help a person who needs food or clothes. This believer does not do any good for anyone!

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a person in your community who is a good person. What makes them a good person? Is it because of what they say, or because of what they do, or both? Pause this audio here.

James describes a believer who does not have food to eat that day, nor the clothes they need to keep warm. Another believer talks to the poor believer and says, "Go in peace." This was something that people often said as a goodbye. The believer also says, "Keep warm and well fed." These words are like a wish, or a prayer, that the poor person will be warm and eat a lot of food. But the believer does not give the poor believer any clothes or

food! James makes it clear that if the believers have faith but do not do good works, then the faith is as useless as a dead thing and worthless.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about somebody in your community who is hungry or poor. Who is responsible for looking after this person? What would you say to this hungry or poor person? What could you do for this person? Pause this audio here.

James knows that when people hear what James says, someone will disagree with James. Someone may say that there are two ways that God saves people. This person says that God saves some people because they trust in Jesus and some people because they do good things.

James challenges anyone who thinks like this to prove that they have true faith when they do not do good actions to prove it. However, people will know that James' faith is real because James also does good actions. James knows that people who disagree with James also say they believe in "one God." The Jewish believers would know and understand the statement "one God" because it was an important statement in Jewish worship. James means that these people accept that there is really one true God. But these people do not trust God and follow God. James wants the believers to understand that there is a difference between when people believe that God is real and when people trust in and follow God.

James says that demons also believe that God is real, but the demons do not trust and follow God. Demons are evil spiritual beings who follow the devil. The demons are so afraid of God that they shake all over. God certainly does not save the demons. So the believers cannot just believe that God is real, like the demons do. The believers must believe and trust in Jesus in a different way, in a deeper way that changes people's lives and leads to good deeds!

James calls anyone who thinks like this a foolish person or an "empty" person. The person is "empty" because that person does not have wise thoughts. James then talks about Abraham and Rahab. These are two people from the Old Testament stories who God considered righteous because they trusted God and acted in a right way.

First, James talks about Abraham. God told Abraham to sacrifice Abraham's son, Isaac, on an altar. An altar is a type of platform on which people offer "sacrifices," or gifts to God. Abraham obeyed God and took Isaac to an altar, but God stopped Abraham before Abraham had to kill Isaac. God provided an animal for Abraham to sacrifice instead.

Stop here and look at a picture of an altar as a group. Pause this audio here.

Abraham showed that Abraham had faith in God by what Abraham did. Because of how Abraham obeyed God, God decided that Abraham was righteous. Someone who is righteous is in a right relationship with God, and God accepts that person. James uses Abraham's story to show that when a person truly trusts in God, that person will act in a good way. So a person's faith is not complete until they act in a good way because of what they believe.

James shows that in another part of Scripture, it says that Abraham trusted God and God considered Abraham righteous. The story of how Abraham was willing to sacrifice Isaac shows how that other part of Scripture is certainly true. James also says that Abraham is God's friend, which shows that Abraham had a good relationship with God. James explains that God declares a person is righteous when that person has the kind of faith that causes them to do good actions as well as to believe and trust God.

James then talks about Rahab, another example of a person in the Old Testament whom God said was righteous. Rahab was a non-Jewish woman who lived in Jericho. Rahab was also a prostitute. A prostitute is a woman who has sex with men in exchange for money. Rahab welcomed some Israelite men who came to spy on the city of Jericho. Rahab hid the men and then sent them out of the city by a safe path. God decided Rahab was righteous because of how Rahab acted.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when a person who was not part of your community did good things for people in your community. The leader of your community welcomed this person into your community because of the person's good actions. How did the community feel about this person? Pause this audio here.

James 2:14–26

James tells the believers they need to understand that when someone says they trust God but does not do good actions, that faith is dead, just like a body that does not breathe is dead. Some translations say a body without a spirit, or the inner part of a person, is dead. If someone says they believe in God, but they do not do good things, their belief is as useless as a body that is not alive.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about the faith or spiritual beliefs of your community or culture. How do these beliefs make a difference in the daily life of the people in your community?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 2:14–26 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four parts.

In the first part: James is talking to the believers. James asks the believers three questions that he does not expect the believers to answer. James wants the believers to understand that if the believers have faith but do not do good works, then the faith is as useless as a dead thing and worthless.

In the second part: James has an imaginary conversation with another person who does not agree with what James is saying. The person who does not agree with James is not real but represents everybody who does not agree with what James is saying. In the imaginary conversation, James talks about Abraham as an example of a righteous person.

In the third part: James speaks to the believers again and explains that a person is righteous, or has a good or right relationship with God, when they do good actions as well as believe and trust God. James then talks about another example of a righteous person. James talks about Rahab.

In the fourth part: James makes a statement about what faith without good actions is like.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers
- A poor brother or sister
- The person that James is talking to in the imaginary conversation
- Abraham
- Isaac
- Rahab
- The Israelite messengers
- And God

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first part, James is talking to believers. James calls the believers "brothers and sisters," although they are not blood relatives. You will remember that James often uses the phrase "brothers" or "brothers and sisters" to show that he is going to start talking about something different.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell the group about something that you want the group to know. Then give the group some new and different information. Pay attention to the words, phrases, and gestures you use so that the group knows you are telling them something different. Pause this audio here.

James starts by asking three questions to emphasize something that the believers should already know and understand. James does not expect the believers to answer the questions. Firstly, James asks if people can claim to trust in Jesus but not do anything because of that trust. The believers should already know that if a person says they have faith, but they do not also do good actions, that kind of faith is useless. Secondly, James asks if that kind of faith or trust saves a person. The believers should already know that God will not save a person from the punishment for their sins if they say they have faith in God but do not do good actions. Thirdly, James

James 2:14–26

asks what good a believer does if they say kind things to a believer who does not have clothes or food, but they do not help that believer. The believers should already know that if a person says kind words to a person who has practical needs, but does not help that person, the kind words do not help the person who speaks them or the person in need.

When James asks the third question, he describes an example of a person who has faith but who does not do good actions. This could be just an example, but it could also be a real situation that had actually happened. In James' example, one of the believers speaks to the poor person. The believer says "Go in peace," which is a way to say goodbye, and wishes that the poor believer would be warm and well-fed. But the believer does not do anything for the poor person. James uses the three questions and the example of the poor person to make it clear to the believers that if the believers have faith but do not do good works, then the faith is as useless as a dead thing and worthless.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about somebody who was leaving your house to go on a journey. Are there special gestures, words, or phrases that you use when the person leaves? Will this change how you translate what the believer says to the poor person in the example that James gives? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some dead things that are useless in your culture? How would you compare something to those dead items to show that both are useless to you? Discuss how you want to translate the way that James says this kind of faith is useless. Pause this audio here.

In the second part, James describes an imaginary conversation between James and another person who does not agree with what James is saying. The conversation did not really happen. The person who does not agree with James is not real but represents everybody who does not agree with what James is saying. James uses the conversation to help explain to the believers that God only saves people who show that their faith is real by acting rightly and well.

In the conversation, the imaginary person says that one person can have faith without doing good actions, and another person can do good actions without having faith. James says that people will know that James' faith is real because James also does good things.

In the imaginary conversation, James says that the other person believes in "one God." The Jewish believers would know and understand the statement "one God" because it was an important statement in Jewish worship. Other people believed in many gods, so this statement showed that the Jews were different from other people. While this statement is true, James shows that this is the most basic thing a person can believe about God. What James means is that there is a difference between just believing that God is real and having faith and trusting and following in God.

Stop here and tell a story about someone who believes there is one God but is not a believer. Or tell a story about someone who believes that a human leader is real, but does not follow or obey that leader. How is the way that person believes different than the way you believe in God? Discuss how you want to translate the way that James talks about someone who believes there is one God, but does not do more than just believe God is real. Pause this audio here.

In the imaginary conversation, James tells the other person that knowing God is real is a good thing, but it is not enough. James says that demons also believe that God is real, but the demons do not trust and follow God. The demons are so afraid of God that they shake all over. Demons are evil spiritual beings who follow the devil. What James means is that true faith must be more than just knowing about God; true faith must change a person's life and make them want to do good actions.

In the imaginary conversation, James continues to talk to the other person. James rebukes the other person and calls him a foolish person. In the original language, James says that the person is "empty" because he does not have wise thoughts.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you were talking to a person who was foolish or unwise. What gestures, words, or phrases do you use when you are telling that person that they are foolish or unwise? What words will you use to translate "foolish" in this passage? Pause this audio here.

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Then James asks another question that he does not expect anyone to answer. James asks if it is true that God considered Abraham righteous because of what Abraham did. James uses the question to start talking about Abraham. Abraham was a person in Old Testament stories. In one Old Testament story, God asked Abraham to build an altar. Abraham built an altar from stone. Then God told Abraham to take Abraham's son, Isaac, to the altar and sacrifice him on the altar. Isaac was not a small child. Isaac was old enough to carry the wood that Abraham needed to make the sacrifice. Abraham obeyed God, but God stopped Abraham before Abraham had to kill Isaac.

James calls Abraham "our father." Abraham was not the literal father of James. Abraham was an ancestor of the Jewish people. James and all the Jewish believers were descendants of Abraham.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about the ancestor who was the beginning of your language group or tribe. What words do you use to describe this person? How will you talk about Abraham as the "father" of James and all the Jewish believers? Pause this audio here.

In the New Testament stories, people often talk about Abraham as a good example of a person who has faith. James says that God considered Abraham righteous. This means that God decided that Abraham was in a right relationship with God, and that God accepted him, because Abraham's actions showed that Abraham had faith in God.

James then repeats some words from the first book of the Bible. The words come from the story about when Abraham trusted God's promise that his descendants would be as many as the stars in the night sky.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: If you have already translated the story in Genesis 15:6, when God promised Abraham that Abraham's descendants would be as many as the stars in the night sky, listen to the story again. Use the same words here that you used in that story for "Abraham believed God and God considered Abraham righteous." Pause this audio here.

James says that God has fulfilled those words from the Old Testament. Here, "fulfilled" means that the words were true. When Abraham was willing to sacrifice Isaac, this showed that Abraham really did believe and trust God. It showed that the earlier words about Abraham being righteous were correct. Abraham's willingness to obey God showed that his faith in God was real.

James also says that Abraham is God's friend. There are two other places in the Old Testament where God calls Abraham "my friend." A friend is a companion who has the same purpose with you. This shows that Abraham is righteous, or in a good relationship with God.

In the third part, James stops the imaginary conversation and talks to the believers again. James explains that a person is righteous, or has a good or right relationship with God, when they do good actions as well as believe and trust God.

James asks another question that he does not expect anyone to answer. James does this to start talking about another example of a person in the Old Testament whom God said was righteous, or in a good or right relationship with God. James asks if God considered Rahab righteous because of how Rahab acted. Rahab was a non-Jewish woman who lived in Jericho. Rahab was also a prostitute. A prostitute is a woman who has sexual relations with men in exchange for money. Rahab welcomed some Israelite messengers who came secretly to find out about the city of Jericho. Rahab gave them shelter and then sent them out of the city by a safe way. God decided Rahab was righteous because of her good actions.

In the fourth part, James finishes by repeating what he said earlier in this passage. James tells the believers that they need to understand that faith without good actions is dead. But this time, James describes faith as if it were a person's body. If a body does not have breath, it is dead. If a person's faith does not include good actions, it is also dead.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it. You may want to use objects or people to show James, the believers, and God. You may also want to use objects or people to show the people that James was telling stories about: a poor brother or sister, the person that James is talking to in the imaginary conversation, Abraham, Isaac, Rahab, and the Israelite messengers.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 2:14–26 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers
- A poor brother or sister
- The person that James is talking to in the imaginary conversation
- Abraham
- Isaac
- Rahab
- The Israelite messengers
- And God

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first part, James calls the believers "brothers and sisters." James says that if a person says they have faith, but they do not also do good actions, that kind of faith is useless. That type of faith will certainly not save the believers from God's punishment for sin.

James then describes a situation where one of the believers speaks to a poor believer. The believer says goodbye to the poor believer and wishes the poor believer would be warm and well-fed. However, the believer does not do anything for the poor person. This is no help at all! James makes it clear that if the believers have faith but do not do good works, then the faith is as useless as a dead thing and worthless.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the poor person, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The believers are saying good things to me, but I am still hungry and cold. The words that they speak do not mean anything to me; or
- I thought the believers would help me, but they just want me to go away; or
- I do not believe that God loves me. I thought believers were meant to do what God wants them to do. It looks like God does not want them to help me.

Continue the drama.

In the second part, James describes an imaginary conversation between James and another person who does not agree with what James is saying. When you are acting this out, remember that the conversation did not really happen.

James says that someone may say that one person can have faith without doing good actions, and another person can do good actions without having faith. James asks if that person can prove that they trust in Jesus Christ when that person does not do good deeds. James can show that James really believes in Jesus by the good actions that James does.

James says that the other person believes in "one God." But James says that knowing God is real is a good thing, but it is not enough. Demons also believe that God is real, but the demons do not trust and follow God. The demons are so afraid of God that they shake all over. James rebukes the other person and calls him a foolish person. James asks if the foolish person needs proof that when someone has faith but does not do good deeds, such faith is no good?

James tells that person to think about their ancestor Abraham. God said that Abraham was a righteous person because of the way Abraham was willing to sacrifice Abraham's son, Isaac, on the altar. It is clear that Abraham not only trusted in God but also did what God wanted Abraham to do. So the way Abraham acted showed that Abraham's faith was real.

The way Abraham acted showed that what someone wrote in the Scripture about Abraham was really true. The Scripture says that Abraham trusted God, and that is why God called Abraham righteous and God's friend.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I knew that Abraham was a righteous man, but I have never understood that it was because of what Abraham did, not just because of what he believed; or
- It is helpful when James explains what he is talking about by reminding us of stories that we know well.

Continue the drama.

In the third part, James explains that a person is righteous, or has a good or right relationship with God, when that person does good actions that show they trust God.

James then talks about Rahab, whom God also said was righteous because of how she acted. Rahab was a prostitute. Rahab welcomed some Israelite men who came secretly to find out about the city of Jericho. Rahab gave these men shelter and then sent them out of the city by a safe way.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This story of Rahab reminds me that anybody can have a good relationship with God if that person trusts God and and does good actions, even if they are not a Jew like me; or
- I do not like this story. I still do not understand how God can have a good relationship with somebody like Rahab, who does not live in a good way.

Continue the drama.

In the fourth part, James tells the believers that they need to understand that faith without deeds is dead, just like a body that does not have breath is dead.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- James has helped me to understand that when I say I believe in God, that is not enough. I need to show by good actions that I follow God and trust him; or
- James is telling me that my faith is like a dead body because I do not do good actions. I feel very uncomfortable.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 2:14–26 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James 2:14–26

James addresses the believers as his **brothers and sisters**. Use the same word or phrase that you used for "dear brothers and sisters" in the previous passage.

James is telling the believers that they need to do good actions and they need to have **faith**. If a person has faith in somebody, it means they trust and commit to follow that person. For more information on faith, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase that you used for faith in the previous passage.

One of the believers may say to another, "Go in peace." People often used this phrase to bless someone, to say goodbye, and to reassure someone.

Stop here and discuss as a group what phrase you will use for "**go in peace**." Look up "go in peace" in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

In the imaginary conversation, James says that the other person believes in one God and that the demons also believe in the one God. In the original language, James uses the same word here for "believe" as he used for "faith" earlier in the passage. Here, the same word has a different meaning. Here, James means that if a person believes something, it just means that that person knows something is true or real. James wants the believers to understand that there is a difference between believing that God is real and having faith and trusting and following in God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **believe** when it just means to believe that something is real. Pause this audio here.

James says that the other person believes in one God and that the demons also believe in the one God. The Jewish believers would know and understand the words "one God" because they were important words in Jewish worship.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for believing in "**one God**." The words come from the Old Testament story in Deuteronomy 6:4, where Moses is speaking to the Jewish people for the last time. If you have already translated that story, use the same word or phrase here. Pause this audio here.

James says that even the demons believe in one God and are afraid of God. Demons are evil spiritual beings who follow the devil.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **demons**. Look up demon in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Pause this audio here.

James says that foolish people want him to prove that they must also do good things. A foolish person acts in an unwise way. James gives the example of Abraham, who offered his son on the altar. Abraham was the ancestor of the Jewish people. An altar is a place where people make offerings or sacrifices to God. An altar is like a table or a platform that people make of earth or large stones.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **foolish** person and for **altar**, and what name you will use for **Abraham**. Look up fool, altar, and Abraham in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words here. Pause this audio here.

James reminds the believers that the **Scripture** says that Abraham was a righteous man. Scripture, or the Scriptures, is what we now call the Old Testament. Look up Scripture in the Master Glossary for more information, and use the same word or phrase you used in previous passages in James.

James gives the example of Abraham and reminds the believers that God said that Abraham was a **righteous** man. This means that Abraham was in a good relationship with God. Look up righteousness in the Master Glossary for more information and use the same word or phrase for righteous as you have used in previous passages.

At the end of this passage, James says that faith without good actions is dead, in the same way that a body without the spirit is dead. Here, spirit means the air that a person breathes into his or her body, which gives them life. When that person stops breathing, the person dies. James is describing faith as if it were a person's body. If faith does not have works, in the same way as a body does not have breath, it is also dead.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **spirit**, and refer to spirit in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word here.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 2:14–26

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (888 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.7 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.3 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

James 3:1–12

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 3:1–12 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 3:1–12 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.

6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 3:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last few passages, James has talked about the connection between what people believe and what people do. In this passage, James talks about something that all people do: speak! James warns believers to be careful about what they say. It is difficult to control what we say, and what we say can have a big impact on other people. Throughout this passage, James compares the way people talk to several different things to show how important and dangerous people's talk can be.

To begin this passage, James first warns that not every believer should try to become a teacher. Here, James means people who teach other believers what God has said and what God means. Believers honored teachers, and some believers may have wanted to become teachers to receive honor. However, teachers have important responsibilities and can affect many people with what the teachers say. God pays careful attention to teachers. On the day that God judges all people, God will judge the teachers very strictly. So James wants people to seriously consider whether God wants them to be teachers.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you choose religious teachers in your culture? How do people treat religious teachers? How should religious teachers act? Pause this audio here.

James reminds the believers that everyone makes mistakes, especially with what they say. If a person never said anything wrong, hurtful, or untrue, that would show that this person is very mature, with a good character. If people can control what they say, which is very difficult, then they would also be able to control everything they do, think, or feel!

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Describe someone you know who is very careful with what they say and says good, kind, and right things. How does this person act and live? Discuss why a person who can control their words is also able to control the way they live. Pause this audio here.

James compares the way a person controls themself to the way people bridle a horse. A horse is a large animal with four legs, which people can ride or use to pull a heavy load. A bridle is a harness that people put around a horse's head and mouth. A person can control a horse with a bridle. A person's tongue is like a bit on a bridle. The bit is the metal part of a bridle that people put in a horse's mouth. Though the bit is much smaller than the horse, a person uses the bit to make the horse go in the right direction. Like a person who controls the bit controls the horse, a person who controls their own tongue controls their body and everything they do. People use their tongues to speak, so James uses the tongue to represent the way people talk.

Stop here and look at a picture of a bridle and bit for a horse as a group. How do you control or lead animals in your culture? Pause this audio here.

A tongue is also like a rudder on a sailing ship. You will remember that a ship is a very large boat. A sailing ship is a type of ship that has at least one sail, which is a large piece of strong cloth that people attach to tall posts on a ship. The wind blows against the cloth, which in turn pushes the whole ship. These ships can be big, and strong winds move the ship on the water. However, the person who steers the ship can control the ship with a rudder. A rudder is a wide, flat piece of wood that people attach to the end of a long pole. A person can push or pull the pole to turn the ship. A rudder is also much smaller than a ship. But a rudder can greatly affect the direction a boat goes, just like the bit can greatly affect the direction a horse goes. In the same way, a person's tongue greatly affects the way a person acts. For example, people use their tongues to boast or say big, important things about themselves.

Stop here and look at pictures of a sailing ship and a ship's rudder as a group. How do you control ships or boats in your culture? If you do not have boats, think of how you control other large vehicles, like a cart or a car. Pause this audio here.

James also compares the tongue to a fire. If someone starts a small fire and does not control the fire, then the fire can spread and burn many things around it, like trees. Just like fire can destroy things, a person can also destroy things because of what they say with their tongues.

Stop here and tell a story about a time when a fire spread and burned many things. Then tell a story about a time when someone caused a lot of trouble because of bad or mean things they said. How are these two stories similar? Pause this audio here.

People can say many evil things with their tongues. Of all the parts of our bodies, the tongue is the one that causes a lot of trouble. What a person says can spread evil throughout that person, including to the places where they think and feel. A person can destroy their entire way of living with their tongue, just like a fire destroys. For example, a person can lie and destroy their reputation. Or a person can speak cruelly and destroy their relationships. These evil ways of speaking, which destroy someone, come from hell. Hell is the place where the devil is, so sometimes hell can mean the devil. The devil wants people to speak in an evil way that destroys themselves and others.

It is easier to control a wild animal than to control what you say with your tongue! People have controlled and continue to control all kinds of animals that fly, swim in the water, walk, or crawl on the ground. However, no one can control the words they speak with their own tongue. People constantly say evil and harmful things with their tongues. It is like the tongue is full of poison that brings death.

Stop here and discuss as a group the kinds of animals that you control in your culture. Which animals are the hardest to control? Tell a story about a time a person tried to control an animal that is hard to control. Pause this audio here.

People also use their tongues inconsistently. People will praise God the Father, then curse other people, even though God is the one who made all people! God created people to resemble God in certain ways, such as the way that people can love, talk, create, and appreciate beauty. It is not right for people to praise God and then wish bad things to happen to the people God created to be like himself!

It is not right or natural for good and bad things to come out of the same place. Think of a spring, or a place where water flows out of a hole in the ground. No spring will have both fresh water and water that people cannot drink. Only one kind of water comes out! God also made plants to grow only one kind of food. Fig trees grow figs, olive trees grow olives, and grapevines grow grapes. Fig trees, olive trees, and grapevines were very common plants in James' area. Figs and grapes were good fruits, and people used olives to make oil. A fig tree cannot grow both figs and olives! In the same way, two kinds of talk, good and bad, should not come out of a person's mouth!

Stop here and look at pictures of a spring, fig trees, olive trees, and grapevines as a group. What are some common plants and trees in your area?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 3:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five parts.

In the first part: James warns the believers that teachers have important responsibilities and consequences if they make mistakes.

In the second part: James says that the tongue, or what people say, can affect what they do, just like a bit and a rudder affect a horse and a ship.

In the third part: James explains how the tongue can also harm things, like a fire does.

In the fourth part: James talks about how hard it is to control the tongue. It is harder for a person to control a tongue than to control any animal!

In the fifth part: James talks about how people use their tongues to act in both good and bad ways. This is not right. God creates our tongues to say good things, not bad things.

The characters in this passage are:

James 3:1–12

- James
- The believers who listen to James' letter
- Teachers of God's word
- God, our Lord and Father
- A mature person
- A person who controls a horse
- A person who steers a ship
- And the people whom believers curse

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

At the beginning of his letter, James warned the believers to watch their tongues or pay attention to what they say. In the previous part of his letter, James told the believers to be sincere and to act in a way that is the same as what they believe. Now, in this passage, James talks more about the way people talk, especially since people can talk in a way that does not show well what they say they believe about God.

In the first part, James calls his listeners his brothers and sisters again as he starts to talk about the next topic. James talks about teachers who teach God's word. Not all believers should teach regularly in the church, and those who do should understand the responsibility. Since James is a teacher, James says that God judges "us teachers" more strictly than other people. This does not refer to the way that God judges unbelievers and sends them to hell, but rather to the way God judges believers. What teachers say and teach can affect many people. God will know if teachers mislead others or do not practice what they teach.

In the second part, James talks about all people, believers and non-believers, when James says that we all stumble, or make mistakes. One way people make mistakes is with what they say. It is really hard for someone not to say anything wrong, or lie, use angry words, insult, and curse others. A person who never says anything wrong would be perfect. Here, James does not necessarily mean that a perfect person is a person who never sins, but rather someone who is complete and mature. This sort of person can completely bridle or control his body, like someone can control a whole horse with a bridle. James talks about controlling a person's body as controlling everything about a person, like the way they act, live, feel, and think.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how would you talk about the whole person, the way a person lives, thinks, acts, and feels? Think about the person you described in step two. What words or phrases would you use to talk about the way that this person is mature and can control their whole self? Pause this audio here.

James uses several comparisons to show how people's words can affect things. James uses a person's tongue to represent the way a person speaks. James compares the tongue to a bit in a horse's mouth and a rudder on a ship. These comparisons show that something very small can affect many things about a person's life.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, when would you use something to represent something else, such as the way James uses the tongue to represent the way people speak? Discuss how you want to translate the tongue throughout this passage. Pause this audio here.

People use a bit, or a small part of the bridle, in a horse's mouth, to control the rest of the horse. James also directs his listeners to think about a ship. A person steers a ship with a rudder, and people often call this person a pilot or boatman.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What words do you have for bridles and bits, or items you use to control animals? Look at a photo again of a bridle and a bit for a horse. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do you call a person who steers a ship? Discuss what words or phrases you want to use for the boatman and rudder. Look again at a photo of a rudder. Pause this audio here.

James then explains the comparison. Like the small bit and the small rudder, the tongue is also a small part of the body. But people use their tongues to talk about big things. For example, a person may say really good things about themselves or make grand speeches about themselves.

In the third part, James compares a person's tongue to a fire to show how a tongue can be dangerous. James tells the believers to think of a fire and how a small flame can cause a great forest, or a lot of trees to burn. James may have quoted a proverb or a wise saying that was common in that time.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What proverbs do you have about fire or things that can destroy? How would you use a proverb to help people to think about what you say? Pause this audio here.

Like a fire, a tongue can also destroy. People use their tongues to lie and say hurtful things that can destroy relationships and reputations. James says the tongue is a world full of evil, which means that the tongue can do much evil. The tongue can corrupt or spread evil throughout a person's body. Again, James uses body to mean everything about a person, not just their physical body. If a person says evil things, they develop their character in an evil way. The tongue can destroy a person's entire life, just like fire does. James says that hell sets the tongue on fire. This means that the devil, who is in hell, gives people power to destroy like a fire does. The devil is the leader of all the evil spirits, and hell is the place where the devil is.

In the fourth part, James compares a person's tongue to animals. James uses four categories to refer to all the animals in the world. When James talks about animals, he means both wild and tame animals that live on land. James also talks about birds, or things that fly. When James says reptiles or crawling things, James means things that move close to the ground, like snakes and insects. James also talks about sea creatures or anything that lives in the water.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, what categories or groups do you divide animals into? How would you refer to all kinds or all the groups of animals? Pause this audio here.

People are able to tame and have tamed all animals, but no one can control everything they say with their own tongue. James calls the tongue a restless evil. This means that the tongue is constantly evil, like something that never stops to rest. The tongue is also full of danger, like something that is full of poison.

In the fifth part, James talks about how people speak or use their tongues inconsistently. People use their tongue to bless or praise God. You may hear in your translation that people use their tongue to bless God or to praise God. When people bless or praise God, they say good things about God, and they speak well about God. Notice that James calls God both Father and "Lord" here. Then people curse, or wish bad and harmful things on people, whom God created to be like himself. James emphasizes how strange it is that people use their mouths to bless and then curse! James exclaims that this is not right! James speaks strongly to his listeners when he calls them brothers and sisters again. James wants the believers to agree that this is not right!

Then James uses two more examples to show how this is certainly not right. James asks two questions, where James expects people to answer "no." James wants to emphasize that these things surely cannot happen. A spring certainly does not give two types of water. A tree cannot grow different kinds of fruit. James uses these questions to correct his listeners. Just like a fig tree cannot grow olives, and a grapevine cannot grow figs, a good person should not say curses.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Some translators choose to use trees and fruits that are common in their area. Discuss how you want to translate the trees and fruits James talks about here. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 3:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers who listen to James' letter
- Teachers of God's word

James 3:1–12

- God, our Lord and Father
- A mature person
- A person who controls a horse
- A person who steers a ship
- And the people whom believers curse

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Dear brothers and sisters, we should not all try to become teachers who teach the word of God. You already know that God will judge us who teach God's word more strictly than other people. All of us frequently make mistakes. But if a person never says anything wrong, that person is complete and mature. That person can completely control himself.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing James, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I worry that people want to become teachers for the wrong reasons; or
- I am a teacher, and I understand what a difficult and important job this is; or
- It is hard for me to always say good and right things!

Ask the person playing the believers who listen to this letter, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I see the way that we all respect teachers. I want to become a teacher so that people respect me too; or
- I am surprised that James warns us not to become teachers. I did not think about the way that teachers can affect people; or
- I want to be complete and mature! I want to learn how to control what I say.

Continue the drama.

This is like when we put a bit in the mouth of a horse to make the horse obey us. When we do this, we can guide the whole horse. For another example, think about a ship with a sail. The ship is big, and strong winds move the ship on the water. But a person who steers can control the ship with just a small rudder. This person can use the rudder to turn the ship in any direction they want. It is the same way with the tongue. Though the tongue is a small part of the body, people use their tongue to boast about great things.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who listen to this letter, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I have seen the way a person controls a horse or a ship. These comparisons help me understand what James means; or
- I want to think carefully about the words I say, since the way I talk can affect all of me.

Continue the drama.

Think about the way a small fire can burn down many trees. Just like a fire destroys things, we can destroy things with the words we say with our tongues. The tongue is the part of the body that is very evil. The tongue can spread evil throughout an entire person. The tongue can destroy our entire lives, like a fire does. Hell gives the tongue power to do this.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing James, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I care about the believers and want them to have peace with each other. I want the believers to understand how important it is to control what they say; or
- I feel sad when people hurt themselves and others with what they say. I do not want the believers to do this!

Continue the drama.

People control and have controlled all kinds of animals that live on the ground, that fly in the air, or live in the water. However, no one can control the words they speak with their own tongue. The tongue constantly does evil things. The tongue is very harmful, like deadly poison. We praise our Lord, who is our Father, with our tongues, but we also use our tongues to curse people, even though God made people to be like himself. We use our mouths to both bless and curse. Brothers and sisters, this is not right!

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I love it when my people honor me. I want people to honor me not just when they speak to me, but with everything they do; or
- I care deeply about all people, so it makes me sad when people curse each other; or
- I do not want people to act in a good way sometimes, but then also act in a bad way. People can hurt each other when they act like this!

Continue the drama.

Obviously, good and bad water do not both flow from the same spring. My fellow believers, a fig tree certainly cannot grow olives, and a grapevine certainly cannot grow figs. In the same way, a spring that gives bad water cannot give good water.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing James, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I will give the believers many examples to help them understand; or
- I want the believers to understand that it is not good or right for people to sometimes act in a good way, but then also act in a bad way. God wants us to consistently act in a good way!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 3:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James says that not everyone should be teachers. Here, James means religious teachers who explain God's word to people.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **teacher**. Look up teacher in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James calls the believers "**brothers**." James often uses the word for brother when he refers to a fellow believer. When there is more than one brother, the word can also mean "brothers and sisters." Use the same word or phrase for brothers, or brothers and sisters, as you used in previous passages.

James 3:1–12

James warns that God **judges** teachers more strictly. When God judges someone, God decides if that person has acted in the right or wrong way, and therefore if the person is guilty or innocent of breaking a law. For more information on judge, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for judge as you used in previous passages.

James says that anyone who is able to control their tongue is **perfect**, or fully mature. Use the same word or phrase for the idea of "perfect" as you used in James 1:17 and 1:25. Perfect is in the Master Glossary.

James compares the way people control their tongues to the way people control a horse. People use a bit and bridle. A bridle is a kind of harness on a horse's head that people use to guide and control the horse. The metal part of the bridle that goes in the horse's mouth is a bit.

Stop here and look at the picture of the bit and bridle again if needed. Discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **bit** and **bridle**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James also talks about a rudder on a sailing ship. A sailing ship has sails or big pieces of cloth that the wind blows against to push the ship. A rudder is usually a wide, flat piece of wood that people attach to a pole. A person who steers the ship holds onto one end of the pole, while the rudder is underwater. When the person pushes or pulls the pole, that person can turn the ship.

Stop here and look at the pictures of the rudder and sailing ship again if needed. Then discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **rudder** and **sailing ship**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The tongue is a very **evil** part of the body. Evil is the opposite of good. For more information on evil, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for evil as you used in previous passages.

The tongue's evil power comes from hell. The word hell is a name for a place where wicked people will receive punishment after they die. Hell is also the place where the **devil** is, so sometimes people use hell to mean the devil. For more information on devil, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **hell**. Look up hell in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Believers use their tongues to praise or bless their Lord, who is their Father. However, people also use their tongues to curse people. When you curse someone, you wish that something bad will happen to that person. Later, James says that people use their mouths to both bless and curse. Sometimes, to bless can mean the same thing as to praise. Both praise and bless can mean to say good things about someone and wish good things for someone. When you bless God, you worship God and thank him for his goodness and his blessings. When you praise God, you speak out loud good things about God and to God, because you recognize that God is good and awesome and that God deserves great honor. So some translations use the word "praise" instead of "bless."

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **praise**, or **bless**, and **curse**. Look up praise, bless, and curse in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Here, James uses the word **Lord** to refer to God the Father. For more information on Lord, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Lord as you used in previous passages.

God made people in the likeness or image of God. An image or picture of a person tells us something about what the person looks like, or what that person's character is like. This does not mean that people physically look like God, because God is spirit and does not have a body as we do. But it means that people represent God on earth. God made people to resemble God in certain ways and do things on behalf of God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **image of God**. Look up "image of God" in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James compares the tongue to a spring. A spring is a place where water flows out of a hole in the ground or rock. A spring can only give one kind of water—water that is good for people to drink or water that is not good for people to drink.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a spring again as needed. Then discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **spring**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James asks if a fig tree can produce olives, or if a grapevine can produce figs.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the photos of a fig tree, figs, an olive tree, olives, and a grapevine and grapes. What words will you use for **fig tree**, **olives**, and **grapevine**?

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 3:1–12

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (865 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (8.0 MB)
- Embodying the Text (5.0 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.6 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

James 3:13–18

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 3:13–18 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 3:13–18 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

James 3:13–18

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 3:13–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last passage, James talked about how hard it is for people to control the way they talk.

Now, in this passage, James talks about true wisdom. Wisdom is the way that people choose between right and wrong actions. God causes people to be truly wise. When people are wise in God's ways, they do not cause disorder, but instead cause peace.

To begin, James speaks to listeners who think themselves wise. James explains that truly wise people live in the good way that God wants. People who are wise are also meek or humble. This means that they are not proud and depend on God. Everyone can see that a person is wise by the way that person lives.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Describe someone you know who is wise. How do you know that person is wise? In your culture, what are some ways that people show that they are wise? Pause this audio here.

But people who are not wise act in a different way. Unwise people envy or feel extremely unhappy when others succeed. Unwise people care more about what they want than about anything else. If someone boasts that he is wise when he is actually jealous of other people and only wants things for himself, then that person lies and is not actually wise!

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Describe someone who is not wise. How do you know that person is not wise? In your culture, what are some actions or ways of life that people know are not wise? Pause this audio here.

Any wisdom or teaching that causes people to envy each other or to care about what they want more than anything else is not the wisdom God teaches. God's Spirit does not give wisdom like that to people. Instead, this wisdom is the kind of wisdom that people in the world have. This false or bad wisdom is the kind that demons have. When people have this kind of wisdom, they do the kind of evil things that demons do, like cause trouble and all other kinds of evil things.

But people with wisdom from God act in a different way. Most importantly, truly wise people are pure, not sinful. These wise people are also peaceful, gentle, and ready to listen to others. These people are very compassionate and show this through their kind actions. These people treat everyone fairly and are sincere. This kind of wisdom affects a whole group of people and causes people to live peacefully. Wise people are peacemakers, which means they both have peace and help others to stop quarrelling and live together peacefully. These peacemakers spread peace like a person spreads and plants seeds. And those peacemakers will produce righteous living that pleases God, just like a person who plants seeds produces crops.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 3:13–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: James begins to talk about wisdom. Wisdom causes people to live in a right and humble way.

James 3:13–18

In the second part: James talks about false wisdom or people who say they are wise but are not really wise.

In the third part: James talks about true wisdom that comes from God and causes good things in people.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers who listen to this letter
- God
- And peacemakers

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In this passage, James wants the believers to understand that truly wise people live in a righteous way. James shows how people with false wisdom, or people who are not really wise, cause disorder and evil. James contrasts those people with truly wise people, who cause peace and righteousness.

James begins the first part with a question and asks, "Who thinks that they are wise and understanding?" James does not expect anyone to answer this question. James shows that he is talking to people who think that they are wise and understanding. These two words mean about the same thing and together mean truly wise.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, if you want to speak to a certain group of people, how do you get their attention? How do you show who you want to speak to? Discuss how you want to translate the beginning of this passage. Pause this audio here.

James tells those people, as well as the other listeners, that two things show whether a person is truly wise. People show they are wise by their good life, or the good and right way they live. Second, people who are wise do good deeds or actions in a meek or humble way.

But there are also people who have envious and selfish feelings in their hearts. People used the word "heart" as special language to represent the part where a person thinks and feels. These people who envy and selfishly want to be better than others sometimes boast that they are wise. But these people lie. These people are not really wise. Remember that in the last passage, James warned that not everyone should be teachers. People often want to be teachers because they think they are wise. But if these people have selfish ambition and envy, they are not really wise and should not be teachers.

In the second part, James explains that the wisdom these envious and selfish people have is not real because it does not come from above, meaning that the wisdom does not come from God. This false wisdom or way of thinking is bad in three ways. It is earthly, which is the opposite of something that God gives. An earthly person is someone who only thinks about things in this world, not what God wants. This wisdom is unspiritual, which means it comes from sinful humans, not the Holy Spirit. Finally, this wisdom is demonic, which means it is the way of thinking that the devil and demons have! If people envy others and are selfish, they have this false wisdom, so they cause trouble and do all kinds of evil things.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: True wisdom comes from God. But people who are not believers often use the word "wise" to talk about ways to live that are really not wise at all. How do you talk about this "wisdom" that is false or not really from God? How will you show in your translation that some people think this thing is wise, but believers know that it is not really wise? Pause this audio here.

In the third part, James talks about the wisdom that God causes people to have. James speaks of wisdom as if it were a person who has good qualities. James means that the people whom God gives wisdom to begin to be like this. Most importantly, these people are pure. Something that is pure is something that is not mixed. A pure person completely devotes themself to God, not to many things. People who devote themselves to God are peaceful, which does not just mean they do not fight. Peaceful people are completely well. These people have a complete life and live in harmony with each other, with nature, and most importantly, with God! Wise people are gentle and willing to submit or listen to others. James says that wise people are full of mercy and good fruit. James uses good fruit as special language to represent good results. A merciful person shows compassion to others. Because a merciful person feels compassion, that person will act to help others, just like a tree will grow good fruit. Wise people are also fair and sincere. When someone is sincere, they do not pretend that they are someone they are not.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: James uses seven words or phrases to describe true wisdom. James says wisdom from God is pure, peaceful, gentle, willing to submit, full of mercy and good fruit, fair, and sincere. Discuss what words or phrases you have for each of these good things that wisdom causes in people. In your language, you may find that you need fewer than seven words or phrases for these good things. Or you may find that you need more than seven words or phrases! Pause this audio here.

James talks more about peace to show how important it is for believers to live in a peaceful way with each other. A wise person acts as a peacemaker. A peacemaker is a person who helps others end a fight and find a peaceful solution to their problem. A peacemaker encourages people to be united and live peacefully with each other.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Describe someone in your community who helps others live peacefully with each other. What names or titles do you have to describe someone who causes people to live peacefully? If you do not have a name for someone like that, how would you describe this person to show how this person causes peace? Pause this audio here.

James compares the way that people sow or plant seeds and then gather or harvest crops to the way a peacemaker acts. If you plant seeds, crops will grow. If you encourage peace in a group of believers, people will act in a righteous way. Wise people who encourage peace are people who produce right living that pleases God, just like people harvest crops.

Stop here and tell a story about a time when you planted a seed, which grew into a plant, and then you ate the plant or something that grew on the plant. Then tell a story about a time when you encouraged others to act in a peaceful way. Compare these two stories together. What work did you have to do in both stories? What were the good things that happened in both stories because of the work you did? Then discuss how you want to translate the way that James compares how wise people encourage peace and how people plant and harvest crops. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 3:13–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers who listen to this letter
- God
- And peacemakers

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

James 3:13–18

Now I want to talk to those of you who think that you are truly wise. You must show you are wise by the way you live. Do good deeds humbly. If you are wise, then you should be humble. But if you envy others and are selfish, do not brag and say you are wise. You are lying. You are not truly wise.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing James, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want people to pay attention and think about whether they are really wise. If they realize they are not wise, then they can learn! If they are not wise, but think they are, they will not try to become really wise; or
- I want the believers to live together in a peaceful way. If the believers envy and are selfish, they will cause trouble for each other! But if the believers are wise and thus humble, they will live in a peaceful way.

Continue the drama.

God does not give people wisdom like this. Instead, this is the kind of wisdom that people in the world have. God's Spirit does not give this kind of wisdom. This "wisdom" is the way that demons think. If people envy others and are selfish, they cause trouble and do all kinds of evil things.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not want to act like demons! That would be horrible! or
- I am ashamed that I have boasted and envied. I must not be as wise as I thought. I should learn how to be wise from God before I try to teach anyone else! or
- I have seen the difference between humble people and people who are selfish. I would rather have the wisdom that humble people have!

Continue the drama.

The people God gives wisdom to are, most importantly, pure. These people are also peaceful, gentle, and they listen to others. These people are very compassionate, so they do many good deeds for others. These people treat everyone fairly and are sincere. Peacemakers are like people who plant and then harvest a crop. People spread peace like a person spreads seeds. This peace produces right living that pleases God, like seeds produce a harvest!

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I love to see my people act in a wise way. This wise way is the way I act. I want my people to learn to act and be like me, since my way of living is the best way; or
- I feel sad when my people do not have peace. I want my people to be able to trust each other and live in a completely good way; or
- If the believers live in this wise way, then other people will see the good way the believers live and want to know more about the wisdom I give.

Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I would love to live in a community of people who act in this wise way! We should learn to be wise in the way God teaches; or
- I feel peace when I am around wise people. I want to be wise and cause peace too!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 3:13–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James speaks about **wisdom**. When someone is wise, that person has wisdom. A person who has wisdom understands many things and is able to make good decisions that lead to good results. It is God who gives

James 3:13–18

wisdom to people. If a person pretends to be wise but does not accept God, then his wisdom is useless, and eventually his plans will fail. For more information on wisdom, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for wisdom as you used in previous passages.

James speaks to people who claim to be wise and understanding. Understanding is another way to say that someone understands many things. These two words together mean truly wise.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for "**wise and understanding**." Pause this audio here.

James talks about people who have envious and selfish feelings in their **heart**. People use the word heart to mean the place where a person's thoughts, feelings, and decisions happen. For more information on heart, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for heart as you used in previous passages.

True wisdom comes from above or from heaven. Heaven is the place where God lives, so this means that true wisdom comes from God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **from above** or **from heaven**. Look up **heaven** in the Master Glossary for more information. Pause this audio here.

James uses three words to describe false wisdom. This wisdom is earthly, unspiritual, demonic. These words are three different ways to show that this wisdom does not come from God. This wisdom comes from earth instead of heaven. This wisdom comes from people instead of God's Spirit. And this wisdom is the way that demons act. Though James does not use the Holy Spirit's name in this passage, James means that this wisdom is not from the Holy Spirit when James calls the wisdom "unspiritual."

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **earthly**, **unspiritual**, and **demonic**. Look up **demon** in the Master Glossary for more information. Pause this audio here.

People who envy and are selfishly ambitious do **evil** things. A selfishly ambitious person cares about what they want more than anything else. And evil is the opposite of good. For more information on evil, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for evil as you used in previous passages.

Truly wise people are **pure**. Pure means not mixed. A pure person is someone who is only good, with nothing bad mixed with it. For more information on pure, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for pure as you used in previous passages.

Truly wise people are peaceful or have **peace**. When people live in peace, they are completely well. These people have a complete life and are living in harmony with each other, with nature, and most importantly, with God! For more information on peace, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for peace as you used in previous passages.

Truly wise people are full of **mercy**. Mercy means goodness, kindness, or compassion. If you see someone in need, and you have pity on that person and help him, then you are showing mercy to that person. For more information on mercy, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for mercy as you used in previous passages.

People who encourage peace produce **righteousness**. Righteousness is right living that pleases God. For more information on righteousness, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for righteousness as you used in previous passages.

Some translations call people who encourage peace "peacemakers." A peacemaker helps others end a fight and find a peaceful solution to their problem. A peacemaker encourages people to be united and live peacefully with each other.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **peacemaker** or **someone who makes peace**. Remember that **peace** is in the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 3:13–18

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (1.0 MB)
- Setting the Stage (2.3 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.6 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

James 4:1–10

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 4:1–10 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 4:1–10 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 4:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last passage, James talked about true wisdom that causes people to have peace with each other and false wisdom that causes trouble. James continues to talk about that trouble in this passage, specifically the way

believers argue and fight. People fight because they selfishly want many things they do not have. To stop these fights, believers must humble themselves and submit to God.

At the beginning of this passage, James says that believers fight and argue because they selfishly want many things. These believers may want things like big houses, or the believers may want to be powerful and popular. James says that because the believers do not get what they want, they murder or purposely kill other people. The believers probably do not actually kill each other. But James wants to remind the believers that other people do kill because they do not have what they want. James warns the believers so the believers will not act like this. James could also be referring to Jesus's teaching. Jesus said that someone who hates another person is like a murderer. James does not want the believers to hate each other either.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you warn people about the bad things that may happen because of the way they act? When are some times when you would mention something that has not yet happened, but could happen if someone continues to act in a bad way? Pause this audio here.

Because the believers want things that others have, the believers fight and argue. But James explains that many of the believers do not ask God for what they want. And if the believers do ask God for something, God does not give it to those believers because those believers ask for selfish reasons. Those believers plan to spend what God gives them on things that will make only those believers happy.

James says that the believers are unfaithful to God like a woman who is unfaithful to her husband. The believers promised that they would be faithful to God, just as a bride promises to be faithful to her husband. But now, the believers are unfaithful to God because the believers love the world. The world represents the evil way that sinful people live, think, and decide what is good and evil. These people do not love God and God's ways. Some believers chose to live like the unbelievers, which makes these believers God's enemies.

James then reminds the believers of what God says in his Scriptures. This is a difficult part of this passage. It is not clear whether the spirit James talks about is the human spirit, which is the part of a human that makes him live, or the Holy Spirit, which is God's Spirit, who lives inside a believer. It is also unclear whether the spirit envies something or whether something envies the spirit. Either way, James shows that the Scriptures agree with what James says: that people who choose to live in a sinful and evil way are God's enemies.

But God gives people even more grace, which means that God is very kind to people. James quotes from the Scriptures to show how God treats proud people who think they are more important and better than other people. Proud people think they do not need God's help. God works against proud people. But God shows kindness to humble people. Humble people know they need God's help and depend on God.

So believers should be humble and submit to God! The believers should obey God, not the devil. The devil is the leader of the evil spirits, who tempts people to sin. If believers refuse to listen to the devil, the devil will no longer tempt and attack them. The believers should keep a close relationship with God, and God will keep a close relationship with them. The believers do this when they no longer sin.

James compares the way that people change their sinful way of life to the way that people prepare for a religious ceremony. In that time, people would take a special bath to make themselves clean and pure, so they were ready to serve God. People become unclean or impure when they sin against God. Whenever a person had become unclean, they had to wash and purify themselves so they would be clean again. This process was a symbol that showed that people removed anything that was dirty or unclean and that separated them from God. James urges the believers to be clean, to act and think in a pure way, not in a sinful way. The believers should completely commit themselves to God instead of to sinful things.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people prepare for a religious ceremony? What do people do to prepare their bodies? How do people prepare their inner selves or the way they think? Pause this audio here.

James wants the believers to feel sad and deeply sorry about the way they sin. Some sinful believers foolishly laugh and are happy because they do not think their sin is serious. However, those who sin should be sad as they change how they act. James does not mean the believers should always be sad, but that the believers must understand how bad their sin is and not just dismiss it.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone did something bad, then showed that they were truly sorry about what they did. How did you know that the person was truly sorry? Pause this audio here.

If believers want what others have and pray selfishly to the Lord, then the believers will not receive good things and will fight. But if believers repent and humble themselves, then the Lord honors the believers and makes the believers truly great.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 4:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: James reminds the believers that they fight and argue because they selfishly want things they do not have.

In the second part: James rebukes the believers who love the way unbelievers live. James shows from the Scriptures that God shows kindness to humble people.

In the third part: James tells the believers to submit themselves to God and be very sad about their sins. God will give great honor to believers who are humble in this way.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers who listen to this letter
- God
- And the devil

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In this passage, James compares the way believers currently act and the way believers should act. Right now, many believers act like unbelievers and selfishly want many things. These believers are proud and do not submit to God. This is why these believers do not receive good things from God, and so the believers fight. However, the believers should be humble and submit to God. Then God will show great kindness to the believers and honor the believers.

James begins the first part with a question. James does not expect anyone to answer this question. James does this to introduce a new topic. James wants the believers to think about why they fight and argue with each other. Fight and argue mean about the same thing: that believers argue and hurt each other.

James then answers his first question with a second question. This question means that the believers already know that they fight because of their selfish desires. These desires are the way that people selfishly want things, such as wealth or to be powerful and popular. James says these selfish desires constantly fight within the believers. This could mean that a person's selfish desires are against the good things that person wants, and so a person's desires are like people who fight to control that person. Or people's selfish desires cause the believers to fight each other.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: James asks a question to get the believers to think about why they fight. In your language, how would you tell people to think about why something happens? James then answers his question with a second question, to emphasize that the believers already know that something is really true. How would you tell people that they already know that something is true? Discuss how you want to translate James' questions here. Pause this audio here.

James says twice that the believers covet or strongly want things, but because they do not receive those things, the believers act in a bad way. James says the believers kill, fight, and argue. The believers already fight and argue, but probably do not kill each other. James probably exaggerates here to surprise the believers, to make

sure the believers really listen to James. But if the believers are not careful, the believers may want something so badly that they would actually kill to get it.

In the second part, James calls the believers adulteresses. An adulteress is a wife who is not faithful to her husband. In the Bible, teachers often compare people who are unfaithful to God to people who are unfaithful to their spouse. James does this to rebuke and shame the believers.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, what would you call unfaithful people in order to shame them? Discuss how you want to translate adultress here in a way that is appropriate in your culture. Pause this audio here.

James then asks another question that James does not expect anyone to answer. James does this to emphasize that the people surely do know how bad friendship with the world is. James uses the world to mean the evil ways that evil people think and act. These people do not love God and God's ways. To be friends with the world means to choose to live and think like evil people. If believers love the evil way of the world, then the believers act in a way that is hostile or opposite to God and God's ways. If a believer decides to be a friend of worldly things in this way, then the believer chooses to be an enemy of God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how do you talk about the sinful way that nonbelievers live? Discuss how you want to translate "friends with the world" or the way that believers choose to live and think like evil people. Pause this audio here.

Again, James asks a question. James means that the believers should not think that the Scripture is wrong. James probably does not quote a specific part of Scripture. Instead, James summarizes many parts of Scripture. James talks about the spirit, which could be the human spirit or the Holy Spirit. James either talks about the way that this spirit is jealous of something or James talks about the way that God is jealous for the spirit, which means the way God strongly desires and cares for this spirit.

Some people think James refers to the human spirit and says that God has strong feelings of jealousy for a person and their spirit. God does not want his people to love the world. God wants this person's total loyalty. Other people think James refers to the way that God gave people a human spirit and how this human spirit causes people to feel jealous of other people. If the Spirit in this portion is the Holy Spirit, then James could mean that God gave people the Holy Spirit, and the Holy Spirit wants us to be loyal to God. Or this could mean that God truly cares about the Holy Spirit, whom God has put in believers.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Which way have you heard this part of the passage translated before? Which way would people in your area be more familiar with or understand better? Discuss how you want to translate this portion. Pause this audio here.

James then reminds the believers that God still gives grace to people. This grace is different than the way that God forgives. This grace is the way that God shows kindness to people when they do not deserve it. James quotes again from the Scriptures, this time from the book of Proverbs, which has wise sayings. God opposes or works against proud people. But God gives grace or shows kindness to humble people.

In the fourth part, James tells the believers how to get back into a good relationship with God. The believers must submit to God and resist the devil. To resist is the opposite of to submit. The believers must oppose the devil or be on the opposite side of the devil and be on God's side instead! This makes the believers God's friends instead of God's enemies! Then the devil will flee from the believers, or no longer tempt and attack the believers.

James tells the believers to draw or move near to God. This means to keep a close relationship with God, like you keep a close relationship with a person whom you are near to. The believers should also clean or get rid of the sinful way they think and act. James says this in two different ways. James compares the way that people get rid of the sinful way they act to the way that a person washes their hands. James also compares the way that people get rid of the sinful way they think to the way that people purify or make themselves clean for a religious ceremony. The believers should purify their hearts. Remember that the heart means the way that a person thinks, feels, and wants. So to purify one's heart means to no longer think evil thoughts and want selfish things.

James calls the believers sinners and double-minded people. Here, sinners means believers who continue to disobey God. Double-minded people are believers who do not live in a consistent way. It is like a person has two

minds or desires that fight each other. One mind wants to please God. The other mind wants to please the world. This person wants two different things, and so the person feels and wants to act in conflicting ways.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, what do you call people who continue to disobey God? What do you call people who are not consistent, or do not act in the same way all the time? Pause this audio here.

Because of their sin, James says that believers should grieve, mourn, and wail, which all mean about the same thing. These words all mean to be sad. When someone wails, that person cries out loud and makes noises that show that the person is deeply sad. The believers must be very sad because of their sin. James tells the believers to be sad three times to emphasize this. James says the believers should not laugh but mourn. The believers should not feel happy but instead feel gloomy, which means to feel guilt and shame.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how would you emphasize that someone should definitely do something? What words do you have for the way that people feel sad, feel shame, and mourn? Pause this audio here.

When the believers act like this, they are humble and show that they know they have disobeyed God. The believers show that they need God's help. And the Lord sees the way humble people act and then exalts them, which means that the Lord honors those people. Notice that James calls God "Lord" here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 4:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers who listen to this letter
- God
- And the devil

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

I want you to think about why you fight and argue with each other so often. You know it is because each of you selfishly wants many different things that are opposite to the good that you should want. You want things, but you do not have them, so you are ready to kill. You are jealous of what others have, but you cannot get those things, so you fight and argue. You do not have the things you want because you do not pray to God for them. When you pray for something, you do not receive it from God because you asked for the wrong reasons. You plan to use what you get for your own evil pleasures.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing James, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am sad when I see and hear about the way believers fight; or
- I am worried that the believers will start to split into different groups who argue all the time; or
- I am upset that the believers care more about themselves than about others.

Continue the drama.

You are unfaithful to God like wives who are unfaithful to their husbands! You should know that if you love the evil ways of the world, then you are against God. So anyone who chooses to love the evil ways of the world is an enemy of God. You must not think that there is no truth in the Scripture. God created each person’s spirit. Like a jealous husband wants his wife to love only him, so God strongly desires us to love only God. But God treats us very kindly. As we know from the Scriptures, “God is against the proud people. But God is kind to humble people.”

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I love the believers and want them to love me too. I do not want the believers to love things that will not bring them peace. Those things hurt the believers! or
- I care about the believers, and if the believers admit that they need help, I will help them! I want to be kind to the believers! or
- I am angry when people are proud and act like they do not need me. These proud people act like they control their own lives, like they are their own god.

Ask the person playing the believers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am ashamed when I listen to James’ letter because I am proud and live like an unbeliever does; or
- I am embarrassed that I do not humbly ask God for help. I should do that whenever I need help! or
- I am so thankful that God is kind and wants to help us.

Continue the drama.

Therefore, obey God and do what he wants you to do. Do not obey the devil, and the devil will quickly leave you. Develop a close relationship with God, and God will cause you to understand him better. You sinners, make the way you act clean, instead of sinful! You hypocrites, make the way you think pure! You should not laugh and be so happy. Become deeply sorry and cry that you have sinned. Be humble to the Lord, and he will honor you.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the devil, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I want to hurt the believers! I will tell the believers all sorts of lies; or
- I will distract the believers so they do not think about the way they sin; or
- I am angry when the believers are humble and have a good relationship with God. Those believers will not listen to me, so I cannot convince them that their sin is good!

Ask the person playing the believers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am thankful that James has reminded us of the truth; or
- I want to have a good relationship with God! I am sad that I often choose to sin instead of to keep a good relationship with God; or
- I am ashamed that I have ignored the way I sin. I should admit my sin to God, because I know God cares for me.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 4:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James criticizes the believers because the believers plan to spend what God gives them on selfish desires or passions. When a person selfishly desires something, that person wants something that will make only that person happy.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **selfish desires**. Pause this audio here.

Sometimes people want something so much that they **murder**, or intentionally kill, someone else. Use the same word for murder, or purposely kill someone, as you use in James 2:11.

James compares the believers to an adulteress. An adulteress is a woman who commits adultery. Adultery is a form of sexual sin. If a married woman has sexual relations with a man who is not her husband, both the woman and the man are guilty of adultery.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **adulteress**. Look up **adultery** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James talks about parts of **Scripture**. When people in the New Testament talk about the Scripture or the Scriptures, they are talking about the part of the Bible that Christians now call the Old Testament. For more information on Scripture, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Scriptures as you used in previous passages.

In one part of this passage, James talks about the spirit God gives us. This spirit could either be the human spirit or the Holy Spirit. The human spirit is the part of a human being that makes him live. This is the invisible inner part of a person. The Holy Spirit is the Spirit of God. The Holy Spirit works in believers' hearts to help them to behave more and more like Jesus, to make them more and more holy. The Holy Spirit is not just a power, but is also a person.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **spirit**. Look up spirit and **Holy Spirit** in the Master Glossary for more information. Discuss as a group how you will translate this portion. Some ways to translate this are: "God has strong feelings of jealousy for a person and their spirit"; or "God gave people a human spirit, and this human spirit causes people to feel jealous of other people"; or "God gave people the Holy Spirit and the Holy Spirit wants us to be loyal to God"; or "God truly cares about the Holy Spirit, whom God has put in believers." Pause this audio here.

In this same part, James talks about jealousy. This could be the way that a human spirit feels jealousy or envy of what others have. Or this could be the way that God feels jealous or zealous for people. This means that God is so passionately devoted to people that God is jealous for that relationship to stay pure.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **jealous** or **envy**, depending on the way you chose to translate this portion. Pause this audio here.

God shows people lots of grace. When someone shows us grace, they do something good for us or give us something good that we do not deserve. Here, grace means something good that God has done for a particular person or something good that God has given to that person.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **grace**. Look up grace in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The believers must resist the devil, and the devil will go away from the believers. The devil is the leader of all evil spirits. His name is also Satan. The devil always tries to destroy God's work. The devil tempts people to disobey God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the **devil**. Look up devil in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James calls the believers sinners. A sinner is someone who continues to do sin, even though he knows it is wrong.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sinner**. Look up **sin** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers to purify their hearts. To purify someone means to make someone clean or pure. In the Bible, a clean person means a person who is fit for service to God—someone who is acceptable to participate in worship to God. Someone can become unclean or impure when they sin against God. Whenever a person had become unclean, they had to perform certain rituals to become clean again. These rituals often included taking a special bath.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **purify**. Look up purify in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

In the Bible, the **heart** is special language for the place where a person's thoughts, feelings, and decisions happen. Someone with an impure heart thinks evil things and makes evil decisions. For more information on heart, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for heart as you used in previous passages.

James calls God "**Lord**" at the end of this passage. When people talk to God or about God, they often call him Lord in order to give him respect. Sometimes it is not clear in the New Testament when the word Lord refers to Jesus or to God the Father. For more information on Lord, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Lord as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 4:1–10

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (980 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (8.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.2 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.4 MB)

- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

James 4:11–17

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 4:11–17 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 4:11–17 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 4:11–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Remember that in the last passage, James said people act in an evil way because people want evil things. James also said that people who live like unbelievers are enemies of God. In this passage, James talks about some of the evil ways those people act. Those people say cruel words about each other. Those people also feel prideful and make plans as if there is no God. Believers must not act in this way.

To begin this passage, James tells the believers not to speak against each other. The believers should not say cruel things about each other or criticize someone in order to make people think badly of that person. The believer who acts more important than others and criticizes others harshly breaks God's law because he does not show love to others. Remember that earlier, James said that the law to love one another is the most important rule God gave people. If a believer breaks that law, then the believer judges the law. This means the believer decides the law is useless, so the believer decides he does not need to obey the law.

This believer acts like a judge who has authority over God's law. But God is the only judge of God's law! God is also the one who gives the laws for all people. God is the only one who has authority to judge people at the end of the world, to either save people or destroy them. Believers certainly have no right to act as if they have God's power to condemn people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who makes laws and acts as a judge when there are problems in your community? What would happen if someone who was not a judge started to act like a judge and make decisions about what is right and wrong? What would you think about that person? Pause this audio here.

James then talks about how proud people plan to get rich in a sinful way. James describes the way people make plans to get rich but ignore God. People choose when they will leave their town, where they will go, how long they will stay, and talk about how much money they will make. These people are confident that what they decide will surely happen. These people do not rely on God's plans because they are proud. These people plan as if there is no God and only plan about what they will do on earth. These people do not know what will happen tomorrow or anytime in the future. These people do not even know what will happen in their own lives!

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, what kind of people go to different towns or villages to trade or sell things? How do people plan or make decisions about these trips? Pause this audio here.

James compares people's lives to mist or smoke. Mist is very small drops of water in the air that look like smoke or a very light rain. Mist often appears in the early morning, before the sun rises. The sun dries out the mist, or the wind blows the smoke away quickly. The mist or smoke only exists for a very short time. In the same way, a person's life is very short, and no one can be certain if they will continue to live tomorrow. Only God knows how

James 4:11–17

long a person will live! So instead, when the believers make plans, the believers should know that the Lord is in control of their lives. The believers should trust the Lord with what will happen tomorrow, because the Lord has control over everything.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about the last time you saw a mist or a bit of smoke. What did it look like? If you can, boil some water to make steam or light a small fire! Look at the way that the mist and the smoke do not last long. In your culture, what do you compare people's lives to in order to show that people's lives are not very long? Pause this audio here.

Right now, however, people, including believers, do not plan like God is in control of their lives. People boast that they are able to do things without any help from God. It is evil to talk like this because people act as if God is not important. People act like they are more important than God and that they control their own lives.

Since James has told the believers the right way to plan and submit to God, the believers know what is right. James warns the believers that if the believers do not do what is right, they sin.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 4:11–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two parts.

In the first part: James tells the believers that they must not speak against each other and disobey God's law that tells them to love each other. Only God can give laws, and the believers must obey those laws.

In the second part: James warns the believers not to plan and brag about the future as if there is no God. People do not know what will happen tomorrow, and so, as believers plan, the believers should trust God and know that God is in control of everything.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers
- The Lord God
- And people who plan in a proud way

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first part, James introduces a new idea again when he calls the believers brothers. Remember that throughout this book, James calls the believers brothers to show his love for the believers. Because James loves the believers, James wants the believers to listen to what is true and change their behavior.

James tells the believers not to slander or speak against each other. This is the way that people say cruel words about someone, especially when that person is not present. This also means the way people criticize someone in order to destroy that person's reputation.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how would you talk about the way that people say cruel words about someone else in order to destroy that person's reputation? Pause this audio here.

A person who speaks against a fellow believer judges or criticizes the believer. Here, to judge or criticize means to accuse others of doing wrong in a mean way. This is not the way a judge judges people in a court. Nor does James mean that people should not judge whether something is right or wrong. James means the believers should not criticize each other in a harsh and unkind way.

When believers criticize and judge each other, the believers criticize and judge the law. The law James talks about here is the law that believers should love one another. To criticize and judge the law means to criticize the law. When someone criticizes the law, they decide they do not need to obey the law. It is like the believer thinks he is a judge who decides whether laws are good or not.

James 4:11–17

But believers are not judges or people who give God's laws. James says there is only one lawgiver and judge. James means that the one lawgiver and judge is God. While human lawmakers and judges make decisions about rules people make, only God makes laws for all people. At the end of the world, God is the only judge who can save or destroy people forever.

James then asks a question he does not expect anyone to answer. James asks, "Who are you to judge your neighbor?" James asks this question to bring shame on those who criticize others. James means that the believers certainly have no right to criticize their neighbors. James probably wants the believers to remember that Jesus taught that their neighbor means anyone they meet, not just the people who live near them.

To begin the second part, James uses a phrase to get people's attention. James wants the believers to listen carefully because James will now warn the believers about something else.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how would you show that you are about to talk about a new topic? How would you tell people to listen closely to what you say, because you are about to talk about something important? Pause this audio here.

James speaks directly to people who plan what they will do in a certain way. James quotes these people, but James does not actually repeat a specific conversation. James just talks about the general way these people plan. This plan sounds like one that a trader or a business person would make. These people make plans about when they will travel to another town to trade. Notice that James does not name a specific town or what the people plan to trade, so this conversation could be like the ones many people have. The problem with the way that these people plan is that they do not ask God about their plans. These people act as if they know everything and completely control their lives.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: As an activity, describe the way that someone you know makes plans to do certain things. Do not just talk about the way that they made one plan, but the way they have made plans several times. Pay attention to the way you show that this is not just one plan, but a way that a person plans in general. Then discuss how you want to translate the way James describes the general way that people plan. Pause this audio here.

But James says that people do not even know what will happen tomorrow. Then James asks the believers what their lives are like. James answers his own question in the next sentence. People's lives are like a mist or a little smoke, which only exists for a short time.

Because people's lives are short and people do not know what will happen in the future, the believers should trust God, because God lives forever and is in control of everything that happens. When the believers plan, the believers should remember that they will only live and do things if the Lord wants them to live and do things. James calls God the Father "Lord" here to remind us that God is the Lord of everything, which means God controls everything.

However, right now, the believers boast about their arrogant or proud plans. This is evil because the believers are proud about what they plan and do. Though the believers know what is right, they choose not to do it. James explains that this is a sin. Sin is not only the way we do what God says is wrong, but it is also when we do not do what God asks us to do. James wants the believers to behave properly, both in how they make plans to do things and in how they do everything else

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 4:11–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James

- The believers
- The Lord God
- And people who plan in a proud way

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

My brothers and sisters, do not say cruel and false words against one another. If any of you says evil words against your fellow believers, you say evil words against the law. If you criticize your fellow believers, you criticize the law. But you are not a judge who can decide whether the law is right or wrong. Your job is to obey the law. It is God who made the law and judges people, not you. God is the one who can rescue people forever and destroy people forever. So you certainly have no right to judge and criticize your fellow believers!

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I sometimes feel angry at my fellow believers, so I say harsh things about them; or
- I feel ashamed that I have acted in a proud way. I did not think about what I did; or
- I am thankful that James has sent us a message about the way we should speak and act. We have had problems in our community because people speak against each other. I hope we can work together and act in a way that honors God.

Ask the person playing James, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am sad that believers act in a harsh way towards each other. I do not want the believers to continue to hurt each other; or
- I am angry that the believers act like they do not need to obey God's law! That is very disrespectful to God! or
- I hope the believers understand that I want to help them. I criticise or point out their mistakes in a loving way, and I speak to them directly. I do not speak harshly about the believers in order to hurt them. I want the believers to have peace, not fight and hurt each other!

Continue the drama.

Listen to me, those of you who say that today or tomorrow you will go to some city and stay a year there to trade and make money. You do not even know what will happen tomorrow! Think about your life! Your life is like some mist or smoke. Your life is here for a little while, then it is gone. Instead of the way you talk now, you should say, "If the Lord wants us to live and do these things, then we shall live and do these things." But right now you boast about your prideful plans. It is wrong to be proud like that. You know what is the right thing to do. So if you do not do it, you have sinned.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am surprised. I did not think about the way that I may sin when I do not do something; or
- I feel humbled when I think about the way that my life is so short. I really do not know what will happen, so I should not act in a proud way! or
- I am thankful that God cares about our plans and wants us to trust God.

James 4:11–17

Ask the person playing God, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I have good plans for each person’s life, and I want people to live in the good way I have planned; or
- I love when the believers prepare and plan in a way that honors me. This shows that the believers are responsible and trust me; or
- I do not like when the believers plan in a proud way and act like they know everything that will happen. The believers lie to themselves when they do this. The believers start to believe that they do not need my help.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 4:11–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James calls the believers his **brothers and sisters**. Use the same word or phrase for brothers and sisters as you used in previous passages.

James says the believers must not slander or speak against each other. This is the way that people say cruel things about each other, often when the other person is not able to defend themselves.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **slander** or **speak against** each other. Pause this audio here.

The believers are not the **judge**. God is the judge. A judge decides if the actions that people do are right or wrong, and therefore if the person is guilty or innocent of breaking a law. A judge will punish the person if the judge decides that the person is guilty of doing wrong. Use the same word or phrase for judge as you used in previous passages. For more information on judge, refer to the Master Glossary.

God is also the only lawgiver, or the one who gives laws for all people. These laws are the laws that God has given to people, as well as the things that Jesus taught to people.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **law giver**, or the person who makes laws. For more information on God’s law, refer to law in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here

The believers should not act like God and judge their neighbors. Neighbors mean any people in your community or whom you meet.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **neighbor**. Look up neighbor in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The believers must understand that they can only do something if it is the **Lord’s** will or if the Lord plans it. James calls God the Father “Lord” here because God has authority over the whole world. Use the same word or phrase for Lord as you used in previous passages. For more information on Lord, refer to the Master Glossary.

It is **evil** for the believers to boast about their prideful plans. Evil is the opposite of good. Use the same word or phrase for evil as you used in previous passages. For more information on evil, refer to the Master Glossary.

If the believers know the good thing they should do, but do not do it, the believers **sin**. Sin is an act of rebellion against God. Use the same word or phrase for sin as you used in previous passages. For more information on sin, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 4:11–17

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (1015 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.0 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.5 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

James 5:1–6

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 5:1–6 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 5:1–6 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 5:1–6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last section, James warned the believers not to speak and plan in a proud way. Now, James talks about rich people who live in a proud and selfish way. James warns that God will punish rich people who hoard their wealth and treat people in an unjust way.

James speaks to rich people in this passage, but James probably does not expect the rich people James talks about to hear his letter. These rich people live in an evil way and could be unbelievers. It is also possible that these rich people are believers, or at least pretend to be believers. James may talk about rich people to encourage

James 5:1–6

the believers. Many believers were poor, and rich people often treated the believers unfairly. James reminds the believers that God will be fair and judge the rich people who mistreat the believers. But James also says this to warn believers not to act or think like these rich people.

James tells these rich people to weep and wail because terrible things will happen to these people. All the rich people's wealth will surely become worthless. It will be like the wealth all rotted away. In this time, rich people would have beautiful clothes, gold, and silver. Beautiful clothes were very expensive, and people considered them a sign that a person was rich. However, James says that moths will eat the rich people's clothes. A moth is a type of insect that chews on clothes and makes holes in the cloth.

Stop here and look at a picture of a moth as a group. What kinds of things or animals destroy people's clothing in your area? Pause this audio here.

James says that the people's gold and silver will rust. When metals such as iron become damp, they develop a reddish coating, which is rust. This rust destroys the metal. Pure gold and silver do not rust. But most gold and silver that people have is mixed with other metals, and so can rust. What James means is that even gold and silver, which people value and usually last a long time, are temporary.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your area, what expensive things do rich people gather to show that they are wealthy? What kinds of things do people store up to feel more safe or secure? Pause this audio here.

The trouble that comes to rich people is more than the way that their wealth goes away. This trouble is the way the rich people will suffer in the last days, when God judges all people. People's wealth cannot help them then. Remember that Jesus also taught that people should not store treasure on earth, where things become rusty and moths destroy. So it is foolish for people to focus on and rely on material things like gold and beautiful clothes.

In fact, an evil person's riches will be evidence to show how evil that person is. On the day that God judges all people, the rust on rich people's gold and silver will be evidence that the rich people did not use their wealth as they should. While these rich people had more than they needed, they did not give anything to help others. Instead, the rich people hoarded their gold and silver for themselves until the gold and silver rusted. Like rust destroys metal, or like fire destroys a body, the rust will also destroy the rich people. It is foolish for people to gather more possessions as if God will not soon judge everyone in the world. James implies that the days we live in will soon end, and God will then judge people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people expect rich people to act? How should rich people use their wealth in a wise way? If the rich person is a believer, how should the rich person act? Pause this audio here.

Another way rich people sin is the way they cheat their workers. Rich people in this time would have a lot of land where they would grow crops. And the rich people would hire workers to take care of the crops. At harvest time, workers would mow or cut stalks of grain to harvest the grain. The rich people are supposed to pay the workers each day for their work. Then the worker could buy food to eat for that day. However, the rich people refuse to pay the workers what the rich people said they would pay. The workers cry out to God for help, and God, the Lord of Hosts, hears the workers. This title, Lord of Hosts, shows God as the powerful commander of the great army of angels in heaven. The rich people should fear this God

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you gather crops at harvest time? How do people with a lot of land hire others to help? How should the person who hires another person treat that hired person? Pause this audio here.

However, the rich people do not fear or honor God. Instead, the rich people live an easy life and have everything they like without doing any hard work. The rich people only think about how they can enjoy the most expensive things and have a good time. But James warns that the rich people are like fattened animals. Farmers would give some animals lots of food so the animals would become fat. Then the farmer would kill the fattened animals for food. Like these animals, the rich people do not work but become fat. The rich people do not try to honor God. Instead, the rich people do whatever gives them comfort and pleasure, so they disobey God. The day that God judges people will be like the farmer's day to kill animals. God will destroy these rich people like a farmer kills a fattened animal.

James 5:1–6

Stop here and tell a story about an animal that lives on a farm and does work for the farmer. Imagine the animal steals food from the other animals, so the other animals do not have enough food. However, the animal that steals becomes fat and lazy. This animal does not want to work anymore! How might that animal feel? What might a farmer do with an animal that is fat and does not work? Pause this audio here.

Rich people also use the law to gain wealth in an illegal way. Rich people are often leaders and friends with other leaders, like judges. Rich people use their power to influence judges and leaders to oppress other people. The rich people probably take poor people to court. Then the rich people order the judges to condemn the poor person, or decide that the poor person should die, even when that poor person has not done what the rich person said they did. These innocent people do not even resist the rich people, because these innocent people are weak and vulnerable.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 5:1–6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: James tells rich people to mourn because their wealth is not only temporary, but also useless. The rich people's wealth cannot help the rich people when God judges all people. In fact, their wealth will be evidence against the rich people.

In the second part: James accuses the rich people because of the way that rich people cheat their workers. James warns the rich people that God knows what the rich people do.

In the third part: James warns the rich that the way they live will cause God to punish them, like the way a farmer will kill a fattened animal.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers who listen to this letter
- The rich people who act in an evil way
- The workers
- And the innocent people

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Throughout this passage, James speaks to rich people. Notice that James does not call these rich people brothers, nor does James tell these people to repent or change the way they act. So these rich people are probably not really believers, even if some may pretend to be. These rich people may not be with the believers when someone reads this letter aloud. James talks about the rich to encourage the believers that God knows about the way the rich people have acted. God will judge the rich people who act in an evil way. But James also warns the believers not to act in the same way that these rich people act. James uses harsh language and describes frightening pictures of the way God judges. James wants the believers to understand how serious this warning is.

To begin the first part, James tells the rich people to listen or pay attention. James says that he speaks to rich people, but notice that James does not condemn these people just because they are rich. James condemns them because of the evil things they do. So James speaks to rich people who act in an evil way.

James tells these rich people to weep and wail, which are two ways to say the same thing. This is the way that people cry in a loud way to show deep sadness. These people should weep because of the misery or great trouble, which is the way God will punish them.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone was very sad because something very terrible happened. How did that person show that they were very sad and upset? What words do you have for the way that people cry aloud to show that they are sad? Pause this audio here.

James 5:1–6

James then talks about what happens to the rich people's wealth. The wealth will disappear like food rots and disappears. Insects like moths eat garments, which are beautiful clothes. Precious metals like gold and silver rust. The wealth certainly will not help the rich people, so James talks about the wealth like it has already disappeared. Some translations say "your wealth will disappear," because it will certainly happen. Some translations say "your wealth has disappeared" to show that while the rich people have wealth now, that wealth is useless. Other translations show that rich people's wealth is useless when they say "your wealth disappears."

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how do you talk about the way that something certainly will happen? As an activity, talk about something that certainly will happen, such as the way a rock will certainly fall if you drop it. Discuss how you want to translate the way James says that wealth rots, moths eat beautiful clothes, and precious metals rust. Pause this audio here.

James talks about the rust on the silver and gold as if the rust is a person who gives evidence in court. When someone sees rust on gold or silver, they know that the owner did not take care of their wealth. Therefore, the rust gives evidence that people did not use their wealth well. God will then punish rich people because of that evidence. So the rust causes harm to people. James says the rust "eats" or cuts into a person's flesh like fire does. The rust represents the bad way a rich person uses their wealth. A person's flesh or body represents the person. So James means that the bad way a rich person uses their wealth will eventually destroy the rich person.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you found evidence that showed something happened, such as when you found dirty footprints that showed that someone had walked through a clean house. What did you learn about how that person had acted or thought from that evidence? How do you talk about the way the thing you found showed something about a person's actions? Pause this audio here.

James begins the second part with another command to "Pay attention!" James now talks about the way the rich people cheat their workers. James talks about the wages or the payment for a day's work as if the wages were people who cry out. Here, cry out means to protest or complain loudly that something is not fair. The wages say that the rich person should have paid the workers. Then James says that the harvesters cry out. The harvesters are the same people as the workers. Harvesters are workers who cut grain and gather it together to remove it from the field.

James says the harvesters' cries have reached the Lord's ears. The Lord can hear the harvesters just as clearly as you can hear someone clearly when they speak right next to your ear. In this time, people would often use one part of something to represent the whole thing. An ear does not hear by itself. When James says the Lord's ears, James means the Lord, who has the ability to hear the workers. James calls God by the title "Lord of Hosts" or "Lord of Heaven's Armies." This means that God is the ruler of every power and spirit.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about the way a person hears something? Discuss how you want to translate the way James says the cries reach or come to the Lord's ears. Since the ear represents the Lord as a whole, you could also choose to say that the Lord hears harvesters' cries. Pause this audio here.

In the third part, James says the way that rich people live will end in a bad way. The rich live in luxury and self-indulgence, which means they live an easy life and have everything they like but do not have to do any hard work. This is the way rich people live on earth and do not think about how they will live after God judges all people.

James says the rich people fatten their hearts. Here, the heart refers to the whole person. James means that the rich people choose to focus on their own comfort instead of on how they can please God. James compares rich people to animals. Both fatten themselves. The rich people do not do work, and so they get fat. The animals also do not work and get fat. Farmers will one day kill the animal for food, and God will one day punish the rich. The farmer kills on the day of slaughter or killing, which is like the day God will judge people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about the way that people focus on their own comfort instead of how they can please God? What do you call the time when a farmer kills an animal for food? Pause this audio here.

James says that the rich people also condemn and murder innocent people. To condemn someone means to declare that the person is guilty and decide how to punish them. The rich people probably did not condemn and

James 5:1–6

kill the innocent people themselves. It is more likely that rich people use the judges to condemn people and even execute people. These innocent or righteous people are normal people who obey the laws and do not do the things that rich people accuse them of. These innocent people do not even resist the rich people.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 5:1–6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers who listen to this letter
- The rich people who act in an evil way
- The workers
- And the innocent people

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Listen to me, you rich people! Cry and wail because terrible things will happen to you. Your wealth will surely become worthless. Insects will ruin your clothes. Your precious metal will rust, and that rust will be evidence against you that you have been selfish with your wealth. It will be as if the rust itself destroys you like fire destroys. You store wealth for the future, but the world will soon end, and then God will judge people.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the rich people, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not have to take care of other people and their families. I only need to think about myself and my family. I will only use my money to make us comfortable; or
- I am very wise. I have saved a lot of money and precious things so that I can live comfortably for my entire life; or
- I am more wealthy than other people. That must mean that God is happy with me! I must have done something to deserve these things.

Ask the person playing James, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am angry that the rich people do not help others when the rich people have more than enough wealth! As I said before, people who know what is right but do not do it are people who sin; or
- I am upset that the rich people often oppress the believers. I will encourage the believers that God knows what the rich people do and will treat people in a just way; or
- Sometimes God gives believers lots of money, too. I want the believers to understand how important it is to use their wealth in a way that honors God. I do not want the believers to act in an evil way.

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Continue the drama.

You refused to pay the people who worked in your fields. These workers call out to God against you. The Lord Almighty has heard the complaints of the harvest workers. While in this world, you have enjoyed life because of your riches, and you have done whatever you wanted. You have made yourselves fat like animals that men prepare for the day when men kill the animals. You have made judges declare that innocent people have disobeyed the law, and then you killed innocent people. These innocent people did not resist you!

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am angry when rich people cheat their workers and oppress innocent people; or
- I care about the workers and the innocent people. I listen to these people and will treat them fairly; or
- I am more powerful than the rich people. I am also just. I will punish the rich people for how they act.

Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel overwhelmed and scared when I see how the rich people treat people. I worry for my family; or
- I feel encouraged when James reminds us that God cares for us and will punish people for the evil way they act; or
- God has given me some wealth. I must be careful to live in the right way, not in an evil way like these rich people. I do not want to accidentally start to care more about my wealth than I care about other people.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 5:1–6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James says that moths eat rich people's clothes. Moths are a kind of insect that chew on and destroy clothes, especially wool clothes.

Stop here and look at a picture of a moth again as a group as needed. Discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **moths**. Pause this audio here.

James says the rust destroys the rich people's flesh like fire destroys flesh. Flesh is the soft part of a person's body between the bones and the skin. Sometimes, people use the word "flesh" to mean a person or a person's body.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **flesh**. Look up flesh in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James calls God the Lord of hosts. The word "hosts" could refer to the armies of Israel or angelic beings, or heavenly bodies, such as stars. This title for God emphasizes that the Lord is the ruler who has all power. The Lord is not only the ruler over a certain region, but he is the ruler of everything on earth and in heaven. This is sometimes translated as Lord Almighty or All-powerful.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Lord of hosts**. Look up **Yahweh of hosts** in the Master Glossary for more information. Pause this audio here.

The rich people fatten their **hearts**. Here, James uses the word heart to refer to the whole person, so sometimes translations just say that the rich people fatten themselves. For more information on heart, refer to the Master Glossary. If you use the word for heart here, use the same word or phrase for heart as you used in previous passages.

The rich people condemn and **murder**, or intentionally kill, **righteous** or innocent people. Someone who is righteous behaves in the right way. For more information on righteous, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same words or phrases for murder and righteous as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word
Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 5:1–6

Audio Content
- Hear and Heart (986 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.0 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

James 5:7–12

Hear and Heart
In this step, hear James 5:7–12 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 5:7–12 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage
Listen to an audio version of James 5:7–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

James 5:7–12

Pause this audio here.

In the last passage, James warned that God will judge rich people for the evil way they have lived. Now, in this passage, James teaches the believers how the believers must live as they wait for the day that God judges all people. The believers must be patient as they suffer and follow the good example of others who were patient and faithful to God in difficult times.

In this passage, James tells the believers to be patient while they wait for the Lord Jesus to return. James wants to encourage the believers, as the believers are in difficult situations. Though other people mistreat the believers, the believers can be calm and hopeful, because the believers know that God will treat everyone fairly when the Lord Jesus returns.

The believers should act like farmers do. A farmer's crops are not ready to harvest right after the farmer plants the seeds. The farmer must wait. The harvest is especially valuable to the farmer right before the harvest, because by that time, the farmer would have very little food left from the last harvest. The farmer needs a good harvest so he will have enough food to last for the next year, and maybe have some extra crops to sell. A farmer also waits patiently for the early and late rains to make the crops grow. In the area where James lived, there are two rainy seasons. Farmers need the rain to soften the ground before they plant seeds in October and November. This rain would also cause the seeds to sprout. Then the farmers need the rain to water the crops before the farmers harvest in April and May. A farmer cannot cause the rains to come any earlier. Just like the farmer must wait for the right time for the rain, so the believers must wait for the right time when the Lord Jesus will return.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do farmers grow plants for food in your area? When is the time to plant, and when is the time to harvest? When do the rains come? Pause this audio here.

The believers should be patient and courageous even in difficult times. During difficult times, when people suffer, it is easy to grumble against each other. But the believers must be patient with each other, not complain or blame each other. If the believers do grumble about each other, God will judge the believers guilty because they treated each other like this. James reminds the believers that God, who will judge people, will soon come. It is like the Judge is at the door of the believers' house, about to enter!

The believers should instead be patient, like the prophets were. These prophets were people who told messages from God to people in the past. Unfortunately, people did not listen to the prophets and often hurt or killed the prophets because those people did not honor God. Though the prophets suffered, the prophets were still patient and faithful to God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remind each other of the stories of some of the prophets, like Isaiah or Jeremiah. Discuss some of the difficult things that happened during those prophets' lives. How do you think those prophets felt when those difficult things happened? Pause this audio here.

James reminds the believers that people honor a person who does not give up, even when that person's life is difficult. James gives an example of one of those people, whose name was Job. Job's story is in the Old Testament. Job continued to trust the Lord God, even when Job lost his wealth, Job's family died, and Job became sick. At the end of Job's story in the Bible, the Lord treated Job kindly. This shows how compassionate and merciful the Lord is, which is something that we learn about the Lord through many stories in the Bible.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remind each other of Job's story. Then think of people from your history who you would talk about as an example of a patient person. What do people think about those patient people and their stories? Why do you repeat and remember those patient people's stories? Pause this audio here.

Then James again warns the believers to speak in the right way. James tells the believers not to swear. People in this time would frequently "swear oaths," or make strong promises to do something or threaten to do something. A person would call upon God or some other thing, like heaven or earth, to be a witness that what the person says is true. The person would also ask that God would punish the person if the person did not keep their promise. A person would do this to convince others that they were really telling the truth. But if a person is honest, they do not need to swear to convince someone else that what they say is true. James wants the believers to be honest and tell the truth all the time. All the believers need to say then is yes or no.

James 5:7–12

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people swear or make serious promises? How do people show that they really do speak the truth? What do people think about the way people swear or take an oath? Pause this audio here.

A person who swears all the time will eventually break their promise or tell a lie. Then this person will be guilty because they used God's name in an unacceptable way. This person will also be guilty because they lied. God will then judge and punish this person because of the way they acted.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 5:7–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: James urges the believers to be patient as they wait for the Lord Jesus to return.

In the second part: James says the believers should follow the good example of patient people, like the prophets and Job.

In the third part: James tells the believers that they should not swear.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers who listen to this message
- The Lord Jesus
- The farmers
- The Lord God
- The prophets
- And Job

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

James is almost at the end of his letter, and James talks some more about some ideas he has already mentioned before. James encourages the believers to persevere, just like he did at the beginning of the letter. James also talks some more about how the believers should speak carefully, as James has discussed in the last few passages. James wants the believers to listen carefully to what he says here. Three times, James asks the believers to listen or pay attention. And James addresses the believers directly several times. James shows how important it is that the believers persevere patiently!

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would a teacher show that she teaches something very important? In your language, what would the teacher say to her students to urge them to listen and pay attention? Pause this audio here.

Since James spoke to rich people in the last passage, James begins this passage with "brothers and sisters" to show that James speaks to the believers again. And remember that in the last passage, James reminded the believers that one day God will judge everyone fairly. That will happen when the Lord Jesus returns, which in this passage James calls the Lord's coming. The believers must be patient while they wait for the day the Lord Jesus returns.

James tells the believers to think about ordinary farmers who grow food. These farmers wait for the valuable crops to grow on their land. These crops are all the fruits, vegetables, and grains that grow in the farmers' fields. The farmers also wait patiently for the early and late rains, or the rains that come in October and November, as well as in April and May. The believers must be patient like the farmers. James also tells the believers to stand firm or strengthen their hearts. This means to have courage and not give up. The believers can be courageous because they know that the Lord Jesus will return soon.

James 5:7–12

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how do you talk about the way that a person is courageous and does not give up? How would you encourage someone to be courageous? Pause this audio here.

One way the believers should be patient is in the way they speak about and to each other. The believers should not grumble or complain about each other. If the believers do grumble about each other, the Lord will judge the believers or declare that the believers are guilty. This is not the same way that the Lord judges unbelievers to be guilty and punishes the unbelievers in hell. James warns the believers to pay attention, because the Judge stands at the door. Remember that a few passages ago, James said that God is the Judge who judges all people. God will see if the believers are treating each other well and punish believers if they are not, with the same kind of judgement they are giving each other.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When James says the Judge is at the door, James says a word that means "Look!" or "Pay attention!" Some translations just say the sentence forcefully. In your language, how do you show that something is surprising, so people should pay attention to it? Discuss how you want to translate how James tells the believers to pay attention here. Pause this audio here.

In the second part, James gives the believers several examples of people who suffered and did not give up. First, James talks about the prophets, who spoke in the name of the Lord. This means that the prophets spoke as representatives of the Lord. Here, "Lord" probably means God the Father. The prophets were patient as they suffered. The believers would probably know the stories of the prophets, so James does not tell the prophets' stories here.

James tells the believers to think of the way that people talk about a person who is steadfast. A steadfast person is someone who does not give up when they face trouble or hard situations. People say that God has blessed that steadfast person. Someone who God blesses has a wholeness of life. James means that these steadfast people are happy or full of joy because they are brave when they go through difficult times and do not give up.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about someone you know who did not give up, even when their life was difficult. What do you and others think about this person? How do you show that you honor or respect the person who persevered? How would you describe this person's life or the way they live? Pause this audio here.

James then talks about Job as another example of a patient person. The believers would also know Job's story and the good things the Lord did for Job at the end of Job's story. Again, the Lord here is probably God the Father. The believers also know that the Lord is full of compassion and mercy, which means that the Lord is very compassionate and merciful. Someone who is compassionate feels deep love and affection for others. James wants the believers to understand that the Lord is kind and cares deeply about the believers. Just as the Lord showed kindness to Job, so the Lord will be kind to those who persevere as they wait for Jesus to return.

In the last scene, James again talks about how people should speak in the right way. James tells the believers not to swear. To swear is different than the way someone says curse words or bad language. This is the way people swear an oath and ask God to testify that they are telling the truth. When people swear an oath, they are asking God to punish them if they do not keep their promise. James says that it is very important that the believers do not swear. James does not necessarily mean that this is the most important thing a believer should do. But it is another very important way for the believers to control their tongues, or the way they talk, which James has said is very important!

James says that the believers should not swear by heaven or earth, which are examples of common oaths. Here, heaven means the place where God lives, and earth means this world where humans live. The believers should not need anything else to make them keep their promises. James wants the believers to be dependable and tell the truth, so there is no need to swear. When the believers say yes, they should mean yes! And when the believers say no, then they should mean no. If the believers continue to swear, then God will condemn the believers or judge and punish them. Again, this punishment is not the way that God punishes unbelievers.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: As an activity, discuss the way that parents teach their children how to speak truthfully. Then discuss how you will translate the way that James says to mean yes when you say "yes." Pause this audio here.

James 5:7–12

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how do you talk about the different ways that people swear? Remember what you discussed in step two about swearing. Discuss how you want to translate the way that James mentions several common ways to swear. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 5:7–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers who listen to this message
- The Lord Jesus
- The farmers
- The Lord God
- The prophets
- And Job

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

So, my brothers and sisters, be patient until the Lord returns. Think about farmers. They wait patiently for the early and late rains to make their valuable crops grow. You, too, be patient and courageous because the Lord Jesus will come soon. Do not grumble about each other, my brothers and sisters. If you do grumble, the Lord will condemn you. Pay attention! The Judge will soon be here—it is like the Judge stands at your door!

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing James, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- When I feel upset about the evil things that people do, I remember that the Lord Jesus will come and treat everyone fairly. I also remember that the Lord Jesus will save everyone who believes in Jesus. Then I feel hopeful, even though I still face difficult things; or
- The believers need each other as they live their lives. The believers can help each other be patient. But the believers cannot help each other if they grumble and complain about each other; or
- I want the believers to remember that the Lord Jesus may come at any time. I do not want the believers to be afraid of the Lord who will judge them, as if the Lord waits to catch them when they do something bad. But I do want the believers to be aware so that when the Lord comes, the believers will be ready!

Continue the drama.

James 5:7–12

Brothers and sisters, follow the example of the prophets who spoke on behalf of the Lord God. The prophets suffered many difficult things, but they were patient. And you know, we call people happy when those people endure even while they suffer. You have heard how Job persevered as he suffered. You also know of the good that the Lord God did for Job in the end. And you know that the Lord is compassionate and merciful.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am amazed when I think about how the prophets were faithful to God, even as they suffered. I want to live like those prophets did; or
- I am encouraged when I hear stories of people who suffered but did not give up. Those people felt the same sadness, worry, and pain that I feel. But those people did not give up. I can be courageous like those people; or
- I have seen the way that the Lord shows compassion to me and to other people! I feel joy when I think about who the Lord is and the way the Lord cares for us.

Ask the person playing Job and the prophets, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- It is more important to obey God than to be comfortable in my life. Even if people kill me, I must still do what God asks me to; or
- Sometimes it is difficult to do what God asks me to do. I weep, and I am in pain. But the Lord God is kind to me and helps me; or
- I want to honor the Lord my God, because he is so great and wonderful. I feel so amazed at God that I want to tell people about God so that they honor God, too.

Continue the drama.

My brothers and sisters, it is most important that you do not use oaths to convince others that you tell the truth. You should not swear by heaven or by this world, or by anything else. Speak the truth without an oath. Say only "yes" when you mean "yes" and say only "no" when you mean "no." If you say more, God will judge you and punish you.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am pleased when the believers trust that I will do what I say I will do and wait patiently for me to act. I always keep my promises; or
- I really want the believers to trust each other. Then, other people will trust the believers too and listen to the good news about Jesus. This makes me happy! or
- I care deeply for the believers and want them to live good, peaceful lives on this earth. The believers can have peaceful lives, even when they are in difficult or sad times. I will show kindness to the believers and help them through any difficulty.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 5:7–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James calls the believers his **brothers and sisters** several times. Use the same word or phrase for brothers and sisters as you used in previous passages.

James talks about the **Lord**'s return. Here, at the beginning of the passage, James probably means Jesus, who will one day return to earth. Later, James talks about the prophets who spoke as the Lord's representatives and how the Lord treated Job. In those portions, James probably means God the Father. For more information on Lord, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Lord as you used in previous passages.

James 5:7–12

James tells the believers to strengthen their hearts. James uses the heart to talk about the place where people feel and think. When people strengthen something, they make it strong and stable so that nothing can shake or break that thing. James uses this phrase to mean that the believers should be courageous and not give up.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **strengthen your heart**. There are other ways to translate this phrase without the word **heart**, but if you do use the word "heart," you can look up heart in the Master Glossary for more information. Pause this audio here.

James says the **Judge** is at the door. A judge is someone who decides if what a person does is right or wrong, and therefore if the person is guilty or innocent of breaking a law. This Judge is God. For more information on judge, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for judge as you used in previous passages.

James wants the believers to remember and think about the prophets. A prophet is a person who gives messages from God to the people. Often, these messages were warnings to people to no longer disobey God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **prophet**. Look up prophet in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The prophets spoke in the name of the Lord. This means that the prophets spoke as representatives of the Lord.

Stop here and discuss as a group what phrase you will use for **speak in the name of the Lord**. Pause this audio here.

People call a person who does not give up "**blessed**." When you call someone blessed, you mean that God has blessed that person. So here, blessed means very happy, or full of joy. For more information on bless, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for blessed as you used in previous passages.

The Lord is compassionate and merciful. When someone has compassion for someone, they have a deep affection or love for that person.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **compassionate**. Look up **compassion** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The word **mercy** means goodness, kindness, or compassion. If you see someone in need, and you have pity on that person and help him, then you show mercy to that person. For more information on mercy, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for mercy or merciful as you used in previous passages.

James tells the believers not to swear. When people make a promise to each other, they can swear an oath to make the promise more serious. When someone swears an oath, they say: "I will absolutely keep my promise. If I do not, God may punish me." If someone did not keep his promise after he swore an oath, we say that he has broken his oath. It was a very disgraceful and dangerous thing to break an oath.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **swear**. Look up **oath** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The believers should not swear by **heaven**. Here, heaven means the place where God lives with his angels. For more information on heaven, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for heaven as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 5:7–12

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (986 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

James 5:13–20

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 5:13–20 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 5:13–20 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 5:13–20 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last passage, James urged the believers to wait patiently for the Lord Jesus to return and to not complain about each other. In this passage, James tells the believers how to live as they wait patiently. The believers should instead say good things as they pray to God. The believers should pray for one another and help each other continue to follow God.

First, James talks about what the believers should do if they are in trouble or have any kind of difficulty. The believers should pray to God! When the believers pray, they can ask God for help and tell God how they feel.

James 5:13–20

And if the believers are happy and content, then the believers should praise God! The believers should sing and make music to God to tell God how much they love, respect, and honor God. In good times and in bad times, the believers should continue their good relationship with God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What songs do you have to praise and celebrate God? You can follow James' instructions right now! If this is a difficult time in your community, pray to God. If this is a happy time in your community, sing a song to celebrate God! Pause this audio here.

Then James talks about what to do if a believer is sick. The sick believer should ask the church elders to come to the sick believer. The elders are the leaders of the local church, or the gathering of believers in that area. The elders should ask God to heal the sick believer and rub some oil on the sick believer. In James' time, people would often rub oil on a sick person as medicine. But believers would also rub or pour oil on a person as a symbol that God is with the believers. The believers would probably use the common oil of that country, which people made from olives and used to cook food and to care for their skin.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you treat and care for sick people? How do believers in your community care for each other when they are sick? What are some actions you do to remind each other that God is with you? Pause this audio here.

The elders pray and pour the oil with the authority the Lord Jesus has given them. When the elders pray to the Lord, the elders must believe strongly in the Lord's power. Then the Lord will heal the sick believer because the elders prayed. If the sick person's sin caused the sickness, then if a person asks for forgiveness, God will also heal them. A person is not always sick because they sinned, but sometimes people are sick as a result of how they sinned.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: There are many different kinds of sickness, and different things cause sicknesses. In your community, what are some things that people believe cause sicknesses? How do you find out what caused a sickness? Pause this audio here.

Because God forgives and heals, all the believers should admit when they have sinned. The believers would not only tell each other that they have disobeyed God, but also talk to God in front of the other believers. The believers should also pray for each other, so that the Lord will heal the believers. When the believers pray, God listens and responds. If a person who is right with God prays, that person's prayers are effective because God will do great things to answer those prayers.

James tells the believers to think of Elijah, who is an example of a righteous person who prayed, and amazing things happened. Elijah was God's prophet many years ago. The people in Elijah's country, Israel, did very bad things, so Elijah prayed that God would punish the people. Elijah asked that God would not allow any rain to fall on the land of Israel. Elijah prayed very earnestly and believed that God would answer Elijah. God answered Elijah and caused no rain to fall in Israel for 3.5 years. But when Elijah did pray for rain, God sent rain from the sky and caused plants to grow out of the earth. James wants the believers to understand that God listens and responds to people when they pray. Elijah was a human just like the believers are. Any believer can have the same power and effect as Elijah did if the believers are right with God and pray.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remind each other of Elijah's story. What do you feel when you remember the amazing things that God did in Elijah's story? In your community, when are some times when you would tell someone's story to encourage someone else? Pause this audio here.

James also encourages the believers to help other believers who no longer obey God. These believers no longer listen to or believe the things God says are true, and so they sin. These people choose to disobey God and are sinners. James says that it is a very important and good thing for the believers to help those sinners, even if it is difficult.

The believers help the sinners repent and return to God. This is how God saves those sinners from spiritual death. If a person does not follow God, that person's soul will be separate from God forever, which is spiritual death. The soul is the inner part of a person that lives even after a person dies. When a believer helps a sinner to follow God again, the soul of the sinner will be safe. God will then save that sinner, so the sinner will not be separate from God anymore. God will also forgive the many sins of the person who returns to God. This is a very important way that the believers can help each other!

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 5:13–20 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: James tells the believers to talk to God in all situations—if the believers have any difficulty, if the believers are happy, if the believers are sick, if the believers have sinned. God will listen, forgive, and heal the believers.

In the second part: James reminds the believers about Elijah, who was an ordinary human like the believers. Elijah prayed, and God did what Elijah asked.

In the third part: James urges the believers to help the believers who no longer obey the true teachings from God.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers who listen
- The Lord God
- The Lord Jesus
- The elders
- Elijah
- And the believer who does not obey the true teachings from God

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

James finishes his letter with a reminder to pray and remember God in all circumstances. This was a common way to end these kinds of letters to the believers.

In the first part, James asks three questions that James then answers. James does this to introduce a new topic and suggest situations that the believers may be in. James wants to tell the believers what to do if they are in these situations. If the believers are in difficult situations, the believers should pray to God. If the believers are happy and cheerful, the believers should sing songs to praise and honor God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: As an activity, teach the group how to do a simple task, like how to make a food or how to grow a plant. Think of some different problems someone might have while they follow your instructions. Talk about those situations and teach the group what to do in those situations. For example, if the food does not have enough flavor, a person should add more spices. If the food is too hot, let the food cool. Then discuss how you want to translate the way James tells the believers what to do in different situations. Pause this audio here.

Then James talks about what to do if a believer is sick. The sick believer should ask the church leaders to come. These church leaders, or elders, should do two things in the name of the Lord, which means by the authority of the Lord Jesus. The elders should pray for the sick person and anoint the sick person with oil. To anoint someone means to pour or rub olive oil on the body of a person, as a symbol that God is with the believer. People would usually put the olive oil on the person's head or forehead. James says that the prayer that the church leaders pray in faith will make the sick believer well. Faith is the way a person trusts in God. So if the church leaders believe strongly in God when they pray, then the sick believer will become healthy again. James clarifies that it is the Lord who heals the sick believer. It is not clear here if "Lord" means Jesus or God the Father. James says the Lord will raise up the sick believer. This is another way to say the Lord will heal that person, as a healthy person can rise from their bed and live normally again.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do you call church leaders in your community? Pause this audio here.

James 5:13–20

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about the way that God heals someone? Discuss how you want to translate the way that James says the Lord will raise up the sick person. Pause this audio here.

God will also forgive the sick person's sins. People are not always sick because they sinned. But sometimes people can get sick because of the way they disobey God. Since God forgives and heals when the believers pray, the believers should regularly confess or admit their sins to each other and pray for each other. God will listen to the believers and heal them.

James explains that the way a righteous person prays is powerful and effective. A righteous person is a person who is right with God and who lives in the way God wants. When a righteous person prays, God causes great things to happen.

In the second part, James reminds the believers of Elijah, a righteous person who prayed. Believers would know Elijah's story, so James just briefly mentions what happened. But people also deeply respected and honored Elijah as an extraordinary person, so James reminds the believers that Elijah was just an ordinary human. Elijah had the same human nature that the believers have.

Elijah prayed very earnestly that no rain would fall on the land, which is the land of Israel. God listened and caused no rain to fall for three and a half years. Then Elijah prayed again, and the heavens gave rain. The heavens are another name for the sky, so rain fell down from the sky and the earth produced crops again.

In the third part, James calls the believers his brothers and sisters again, to show that James will talk about one more topic before the end of the letter. James talks about a believer who wanders from the truth. This person is a sinner because they choose to no longer believe and obey the true teachings from God, just like a person chooses to wander away from a good road. If this happens, another believer can lead the sinner to return to God, like a person leads a friend back to the right road. This believer helps the sinner to leave his way of error, or bad way of life.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about the way that people choose to live in the wrong way instead of God's right way? What would you compare those ways of life to? Discuss how you want to translate the way that James talks about the way someone rejects God, like a person rejects a good road. Pause this audio here.

When a believer helps a sinner like this, the believer should know that God causes good things because of what the believer did. God saves the sinner's soul from death. Death here means the way that unbelievers will be eternally separate from God. Because of the believer, God also covers over many sins. This means that God forgives all the sinner's sins, no matter how many times the sinner has sinned.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about the way that unbelievers will be separate from God forever? Discuss how you want to translate the way that James says the believer will save the sinner from death. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about the way that God forgives a believer's sins? Discuss how you want to translate the way that God covers over or forgives someone's sin because of what the believer did. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 5:13–20 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers who listen
- The Lord God

- The Lord Jesus
- The elders
- Elijah
- And the believer who does not obey the true teachings from God

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

When you are in difficult situations, pray and ask God to help you. When you are happy, you should sing songs to praise God. If you are sick, you should ask the church leaders to come to you. The leaders should pray for you and put oil on you with the authority that the Lord has given to the elders. When the elders pray and trust the Lord, you will get well, because the Lord will heal you. And if you have sinned, God will forgive you. So you believers should admit to other believers that you have disobeyed God. Pray for each other so that the Lord will heal you. When a person who is right with God prays, great things happen.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Lord Jesus, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I love to hear the believers when they are happy and celebrate! I feel joy when the believers are happy. I love the beautiful songs the believers sing to me! or
- I also want to listen to the believers when they are sad or in pain. I feel sad when my children are in danger or difficult circumstances. I will comfort and protect my children; or
- I care deeply about the believers and will help them. If the believers ask for forgiveness, I will forgive them!

Ask the person playing the elders, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel sad when members of our community are sick. We want to help them! or
- We have learned how to trust God in all situations, which is why the believers trust us to lead and encourage other believers; or
- I am encouraged when I hear James say that God will listen and heal believers who are sick.

Continue the drama.

Think about Elijah. Elijah was a human, just like all of us. Elijah prayed very earnestly that God would not allow any rain to fall on the land of Israel. And there was no rain in Israel for three and a half years. After the three and a half years, Elijah prayed again, and God sent rain from the sky and caused crops to grow out of the earth.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing James, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want the believers to remind each other of what God has done in the past, like in Elijah's story. This will help the believers trust God as they remember what God has done! or
- I feel amazed when I think about the stories of how God answers prayers. I also feel amazed when I remember what God has done in my life, too! or
- These amazing things happened not because Elijah did something special that other people cannot do. Elijah prayed! And the believers can pray too!

Continue the drama.

James 5:13–20

My brothers and sisters, eventually, one of you believers might no longer obey the true teachings from God. If that happens, another believer can help the sinner repent and return to God. The believer should know that whoever helps a sinner return to God will save that sinner so that they will not die spiritually. God will forgive the many sins of the person who returns to God.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I care deeply about the believers and want them to care deeply about each other. I want the believers to help each other love and follow me, even when it is hard; or
- I feel sad when believers reject me and live in the wrong way. Those believers hurt themselves and destroy our good relationship; or
- I promised that I would forgive people's sins if they ask for forgiveness, and I always keep my promises.

Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I have worried about believers who choose to reject God. I want to lead these people back to God, so that God will forgive their sins; or
- I feel relieved that we can talk to God at all times. We do not have to be perfect to speak to God. In fact, God asks us to pray to him about our sin! I am still amazed that God promises to forgive our sins when we apologise to him! or
- I am thankful that God will forgive us when we sin, heal us when we are sick, and listen to us when we talk to him. God really does love us!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 5:13–20 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

When the believers are in difficult situations, the believers should pray. When you pray, you talk to God. You might praise God, thank him, ask for help, tell him about the wrong things you have done, ask God to help other people, or you might just cry to God because you feel so sad.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **pray**. Look up pray in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

When the believers are happy, they should sing songs to praise God. When you praise God, you speak out loud good things about God and to God, because you recognize that God is good and awesome and that God deserves great honor. You thank God for the good things he has done and the blessings he will give. Many times, people create and sing songs to praise God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **praise**. Look up praise in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

If a believer is sick, the believer should ask the elders of the church to come and pray for the believer. Elders are people in the church who have authority. The apostles, such as Paul, chose the elders. People in the community respected the elders. T he church is a community of people who believe in Jesus. Sometimes the word church means a group of believers in one specific place, as it does here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **elder** and **church**. Look up elder and church in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The elders should pray and anoint the sick believer. To anoint someone means to pour sweet-smelling oil over that person. This oil was a symbol of how God was with the believers and how God can heal the believers.

James 5:13–20

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **anoint**. Look up anoint in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The elders should pray and anoint in the name of the **Lord**, or with the authority that the Lord gives the elders. A Lord is someone who has full authority over people, so people called God "Lord" to show respect. Here, James probably means the Lord Jesus. For more information on Lord, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Lord as you used in previous passages.

If the elders pray with **faith**, the Lord will heal the sick believers. If you have faith in God, you believe in God. You trust that God will fulfill all his promises, even when it seems impossible. For more information on faith, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for faith as you used in previous passages.

If a sick believer has **sinned**, God will forgive that person. Anytime that a person disobeys God's laws, they sin. For more information on sin, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for sin as you used in previous passages.

God forgives the believers. When you forgive someone who has done something bad to you, you stop being angry with that person. You no longer want to take revenge or to give punishment.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **forgive**. Look up forgive in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

When a **righteous** person prays, great and powerful things happen. Someone who is righteous is a person who behaves in the right way. Only a righteous person can have a good relationship with God. For more information on righteous, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for righteous as you used in previous passages.

When Elijah prayed for rain, rain fell from the **heavens**. Here, the word "heavens" probably means the sky. For more information on heaven, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for heaven or sky as you used in previous passages.

James calls the believers his **brothers and sisters** towards the end of his letter. Use the same word or phrase for brothers and sisters as you used in previous passages.

James talks about what happens when a believer causes a **sinner** to obey God again. A sinner is someone who continues to sin, even though that person knows it is wrong. For more information on sinner, refer to sin in the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for sinner as you used in previous passages.

That believer saves the sinner's **soul** from death. The soul is what people call the total invisible, inner part of a person. This part of a person may live on even after their body dies. The words heart, mind, soul, and spirit all have to do with the inner, invisible part of a person, but each of them has a slightly different use. Sometimes, people use the word soul to refer to a whole person, their visible and invisible parts, so some translations just say "the person." For more information on soul, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for soul as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

James 5:13–20

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 5:13–20

Audio Content

- Setting the Stage (4.7 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.9 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.3 MB)